

[NOT-FIC ENDING / DISCONTINUED] Honorary bird

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[NOT-FIC ENDING / DISCONTINUED] Honorary bird

by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

Jason Todd rediscovers the joys of human socialization.

The Batfamily discovers Jason can be something else than a rebellious asshole, if given a chance.

NOTE: THIS FIC DOES NOT HAVE ALL THE CHAPTERS WRITTEN OUT AS PROSE.

The ending is a summary/notfic, as I had it all planned out but did not have it in me to actually write it. I decided to give this some kind of closure this way.

Notes

Second part in the series, sequel to '[In oculis veritas](#)'. It is recommended you read the previous work, but I tried to make it optional and include brief summary/hints of what happened in the story.

Inspiration link added halfway thru writing this - the fic inspired me for some epilogue stuff. And it's also just super friggin good and if you like this story go read that one.

- Inspired by [The Ouija Boy](#) by [SunnyBlue](#)

Chapter 1: Jason

Chapter Summary

How to befriend a Jason? Talk to him about books.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

Making friends after you spent nearly your entire life only socializing with vigilantes or outlaws was, in Jason's ranking, one of the hardest things on Earth. Possibly the only harder things are changing Batman's mind or protecting your digital data from Babs and Tim.

But unlike those two things, he wasn't going to give up on this one. Well, at least not yet.

Julianna Powell, who ~~claimed~~ *was* friends with Jason's ghost, and who he nearly shot because he's about as good with dealing with the past and his emotions as Bruce is — she was too promising of a person to give up that quickly. For starters, she was genuinely interested in him, and didn't see him as another vigilante soldier to use in a mission. That alone was something that drew Jason to this *situation* like a moth to a flame.

Their initial hang out, the lunch back then, was awkward as hell and stiff and painfully polite. He wasn't surprised, though. He did threaten her with a gun just a few hours earlier. Honestly, he wouldn't hold it against her if she didn't show up at all.

Still, she did, and they talked, like normal people, and he found it *entertaining*. The topic quickly changed into literature and Jason was refreshed to hear a person speak about Hamlet in the same passionate way that he *felt* about the story, but never could express because he has a *reputation* to uphold. Dick would never let him off the hook if he ever shared his analysis of the Shakespearean prophecy.

So when they parted, both tired out of their minds, Jason was *excited* to meet her again. Hear the rest of her take on Dante's Inferno. Maybe get a book recommendation. Only later he realized that if he wanted that to happen, he would have to make the first step. Julianna didn't, after all, have any way to contact him. Except maybe approaching him again if she ever ran into Red Hood. Which he honestly doubted she would attempt ever again.

And that's how he found himself staring at his phone, with her number typed into the dialing screen, completely frozen. With what? He wasn't sure. Fear, perhaps, the kind he hadn't felt in a *really* long time. Since he was a teen, maybe. Maybe never, really.

Eventually, Jason chickened out of calling her, threw his phone on the table and himself on the sofa, groaning. He didn't even know what to say to her, anyway. That's why when he heard the mobile ring, it made him jump like a startled little kid.

Jason grabbed the thing and looked at the caller ID. It wasn't Julianna — it couldn't have been, but his brain expected it anyway, somehow — and it was honestly the last person he expected.

“What do you want, Demon Spawn?”

“Is it handled? A week passed.”

He frowned.

“What?”

“The case you had shared with Grayson. We agreed that I'll give you a week before escalating it.”

He groaned.

“Yeah, it's none of your business but I took care of it. You can fuck off.”

“Todd says it's been dealt with,” Damian's voice was only slightly quieter, which meant he was speaking to someone next to him and didn't even attempt to hide it. Brat.

“Oh my god, I hope he didn't shoot her.”

It was Dick in the background. Of course it was Dick. A little shuffling, a muffled and offended ‘hey!’ from Damian and Grayson's voice became clearer in the phone's speakers.

“You didn't shoot her, right? You always make it sound like that when you say you ‘dealt with’ something..”

Jason sighed in annoyance. A reputation alright.

“I didn't shoot her.”

Dick sighed in relief.

“So it was about a woman? Pathetic,” could be heard from next to Dick, and more shuffling.
“Give me back my phone, Grayson.”

Jason didn't want to talk to them, and he didn't want to hear them argue about Damian's phone, so he just hung up. As expected, a few moments later he got a text from Dick.

what did you do?

A series of texts, really.

what was it all about? was she telling the truth?

Jaybird please i need to know

A barrage, more like it.

Jay.

Jay please

Im going to call her myself if you dont tell me

That was enough. Jason was not going to let Nightwing stick his nose into his matters. So he had to reply. But how? Could he get away with telling him nothing?

i handled it. drop it.

He didn't have to wait long for a reply.

im going to do it

No, he wasn't going to get away without telling Dick at least *something*.

she told truth. I talked her out of getting involved. happy now?

He didn't have to wait long for a reply beep.

no but im not going to get more out of you now so im just gonna pout and bide my time

Jason sighed again. Getting Dick off his case was hard and wholly unpleasant. There were few things he hated more than nosy people.

But the whole ordeal gave him an idea. He wasn't sure why he hadn't thought of it before.

Hi, this is Jason. Thought I'd give you my number. See you sometime soon again?

He looked at the text on his phone screen, thumb hovering over the Send button. It had the same kind of distanced politeness about it that was between them in person. Was it a good thing? Did he want to send something like this? Was it... him?

He erased the entire text and started over.

Jason here. Wanna grab coffee tomorrow?

The moment he finished typing it out, he quickly erased it, feeling slightly embarrassed for some reason.

Last try.

Jason here. When's the next book club meeting?

That. Now that sounded more like him. He hit Send. And then spent good five minutes staring at his phone before he realized what he's doing. Jason threw it on the sofa and walked out of the room. He had to get some things out of his system, so he headed straight for a nearby gym.

The next ‘book club meeting’ was the next day, and from then on it became a weekly thing. Sometimes even bi-weekly.

In time, he relaxed around her. Mostly after he read through her Robin notebook and carefully asked the right questions. It appeared that however close they were in the past, Jason kept his most important secrets; while she knew a good deal of *juicy* details about him, and Crime Alley, and Batman, and even Nightwing, she had no clue about their identities (well, save for his own name, but even that one he learned he’d told her good couple years after they met) or anything other that could *compromise* the vigilantes. That was a relief. And with that relief, he was able to talk to her more easily.

She, on the other hand, relaxed a bit each time she saw him unarmed and in civvies, heard him talk about literature. Possibly when he stopped acting like he was testing her. Maybe Julianna also psychoanalyzed him and deduced he no longer wants to kill her. She was a shrink, after all, even if currently underemployed. He was curious about what she actually thought of him. But he’d never dare to ask.

He did dare to do many other things, though. Like asking her to come over instead of meeting her in a diner or coffee shop. Calling her to talk about nothing when he was down and Roy was being an ass, or too busy to be bothered. Doing groceries for her when she admitted she forgot. She forgot about a lot of things, actually. Or rather, she prioritized a lot of things over her own day-to-day business. Jason quickly learned how packed her schedule was, mostly with volunteer psych advice and free therapy for people who couldn’t afford it. He figured the ‘call me if you need to talk’ cards were part of that.

Despite that, and his own rather *unusual* lifestyle, he strived to hang out with her regularly. Their meetings slowly morphed from ‘book club’ into more of a... story club. Julianna had a talent to make any medium sound like a ‘good read’ even if she was talking about a TV series or a video game. Which she enjoyed quite a lot, too. Although she admitted it's half because she likes them, half because she wants to stay up to date with things that might help her connect with younger patients. He didn’t mind. It was a conversation topic like any other. After a while, even that wasn’t needed. They started talking about *life* in general. It was an odd sensation. To hear someone complain about coworkers and traffic instead of rambling about the political situation of the middle east or the new crime ring of drug dealers in the south end.

He struggled to reply with the same at first. His ‘work’ was all about drug dealers after all. Jason didn’t want to involve her in that kind of thing, for safety reasons and for... his own sake. There was something soothing about talking with a civilian. Someone who wasn’t part of the entire *vigilante* thing. Luckily for him, Julianna seemed to notice, and she knew the right questions to keep the conversation going. She’d start with standard things, like his favorite food, and an hour later he would find himself passionately explaining to her why Dijon mustard is a travesty or how cucumber is the superior sandwich ingredient to tomato.

With all that, Jason almost didn’t notice when it was a few months later and they regularly laughed over coffee like lifelong friends.

“You know,” Jason said one afternoon, not bothering to pause the Netflix show they were watching. “It *does* feel like I’ve known you for ages.”

Julianna looked at him for a while, her face somehow both surprised and utterly *delighted*. Then, struggling to regain composure and make her voice stop trembling, she spoke up.

“I’m- I didn’t want to... assume anything. Pressure you?”

“You didn’t. Don’t worry,” Jason reached over and ruffled her hair like she was one of his brothers. “I guess we just think alike enough to, yanno. Get to here from the starting point. All over again,” he grinned.

She giggled and smiled. “I’m glad you’re here.”

Jason smiled too, then went back to watching the TV.

“I’m glad someone thinks so.”

He never expected how much change this sentiment would bring not only his, but all Bats’ lives.

Chapter End Notes

This had no beta reading and it shows. Sorry.

Chapter 2: Jason/Red Hood

Chapter Summary

Disagreements are a part of socialization, Jay.

Chapter Notes

With a dedication to Lola, who commented on the previous chapter, the first person to ever leave a comment on my fics <3

Ring. Ring. Ring.

Who the fuck called him at the unholy hour of eleven in the morning?

Jason stumbled to find his phone, then fumbled with it for a moment, cursing under his breath as he tried to find the button to reject the call. Anyone who woke him up could go fuck themselves.

Once it was silent, he threw it away. One day he was going to break his phone because of doing things like that.

Ring. Ring. Ring.

“Fuuuuuuuck.”

Jason rolled out of his bed and angrily grabbed the phone.

“What?!” he growled into it.

“*Someone’s got off on the wrong foot, huh?*” Julianna chirped on the other side. He immediately regretted barking at her. But he would rather die than to admit that. “*Or did you have a long night again?*”

“Yea,” he yawned loudly.

“*I woke you up?*”

“Something like that.”

“*Oh. Sorry! I’ll call later, then —*”

“Nah I’m already up, whatever. What’s the matter?”

*“I got a call from a kid in, uh, **deep** downtown, and he wants to talk, but only can make it out safely when his... guardians are already asleep. You know. I was thinking you could give me some advice on how not to get shanked around those parts.”*

Jason let out a long sigh and massaged the bridge of his nose with his free hand. Then he realized how much of a *Bruce* gesture it is, cursed under his breath, and sat back on the bed.

He thought for a moment how to break it to her that just outright *dying* was the *best-case* scenario for her if she went anywhere farther than the 122nd street.

“Yeah I got you one good advice: **don’t go**,” his tone was grave and commanding. Her response was not adequate to it.

“Jay.”

“Seriously.”

“You can’t stop me.”

He laughed heartily. Boy, was she good at making him laugh with her pitiful ‘threats’. Only maybe Dick could make those words sound serious. If someone like Tim or Damian said that, sure, he’d also *consider*. Jason was still pretty sure he could at least knock them out and keep their asses out of trouble if he needed to. But her? Locking her in a room would be enough.

“Oh, I definitely can.”

“Okay, yes, fine. You can stop me, physically, but that would make me angry.”

“Ooooh no, I’m so scared,” he faked a gasp, then giggled. “Do you really think I’d be intimidated by your anger? Please.”

There was silence on the other side instead of the expected indignation.

“I wasn’t trying to intimidate you,” Julianna replied, speaking slowly as if she wasn’t sure Jason understood English. He frowned. “I was just saying that if you tied me up or locked me away or whatever you were implying, I would probably not enjoy being around you anymore.”

Now that. That sounded like a real threat. Jason didn’t like to be threatened that way.

“So now your company has a price, huh?” he growled into the phone, eyes squinting in suspicion. “I gotta be a good boy or you’ll never talk to me again, is that it?—”

“Jason, no!” she immediately interrupted him, sounding distraught and a *little* panicked. *“No, that’s not what I meant! Not at all!”*

“Well that’s what you said!” he was *this* close to just disconnecting. And possibly throwing the phone hard enough to at least crack the screen.

“What I said was if someone breaks my trust by ignoring my boundaries, I will no longer trust them to respect me the next time and would be uncomfortable hanging out with such a person.”

“It would’ve been for **your own good**! You’re *insane* if you think you can waltz into Crime Alley looking like a lost little lamb like you always do and *not* get immediately swiped into trafficking!”

*“I **don’t** think I can waltz in there like that and that’s why I’m asking **you** for **help**”* Julianna cried out. Quite literally. He was fairly sure she was on the verge of sobbing. *“For help, not for acting like you’re my father and know better what’s good for me and will ignore what I say because I’m young and stupid!”*

Jason got irrationally *angrier* after she said that, and he wasn’t sure why. He wasn’t good at handling these bouts of irrational anger, either.

“There’s nothing I can tell you except **stay home**,” he barked out. “So if you want my help, that’s all you’re going to get. If you want to get yourself killed, that’s fine by me. Be my guest! We’ll see if **you** had any unfinished business, huh?”

He fully expected her to hang up on him, or maybe start a yelling match *then* hang up, like any Bat would. Instead, there was a brief silence.

“My break’s about to end,” Julianna spoke right as he was about to pick up his tirade of mocking and sarcasm. Her voice was small and weak and yet, so annoyingly controlled. *“I’ll come over after work so we can talk in person, okay?”*

Jason growled angrily again. “Can’t guarantee I’ll be around.”

“I know. I’ll come anyway. Bye, Jay. Have a nice day.” And with that, she disconnected.

Have a nice day and fuck you too, Powell!

He dropped back on his bed and covered his face. Why people insisted on being stupid, and assholes about it? He didn’t want to think about it, so instead he went to his kitchen, made himself some instant ramen, and ate it quickly. Then headed to his own little vigilante cave to focus on motherfuckers he needed to bring down.

Jason only thought about Julianna Powell next time when his phone beeped, and he absent-mindedly took a glance at it, slowly chewing his 8th pizza slice today. He had been trying to figure out how to approach these new problems with Black Mask for hours now, and his brain started to feel like a slushie.

knock knock?

He stared at it with tired eyes for a moment. Maybe if he won’t talk to her, she’ll figure out she really has no idea how to go about prancing into Gotham’s infamous crime zone. He

hoped she would. The notification faded out and Jason attempted to go back to work. The phone made a noise again. He tried not to look. He did anyway.

i left you a bag of hotdogs on the doorknob. tuesday still up?

Jason mulled over replying. Finally decided against it. He was not going to be swayed by some snacks.

He was, though, going to be swayed by Julianna's tracker (Bat paranoia never leaves you once it sets in, really) entering Crime Alley. With a groan, he stood up, grabbed his helmet, put on the armor and the jacket, then headed out to catch up with that idiot and stop her from getting herself killed.

Again.

It was something hard to admit — he ought to give her more credit than he initially did. Julianna Powell was nowhere near the cunning of a local street rat, nor the trained strategy of a Bat, but she *did* fare on the streets way better than he anticipated.

Jason looked at her from his relatively safe perch of a fire escape, high above the street. He made sure to keep her in his sights but tried to be inconspicuous about it, stay a little further. On one side because he *definitely* didn't want her to know he was keeping an eye on her. On the other, because it would be an even greater disaster if *anyone else* knew he was keeping an eye on her.

Powell put on possibly her worst clothes, which made her stand out less than she would in her normal, middle-class attire. Pulled on an oversized hoodie over her head, making her look less feminine, less fragile, and less frightened. The thick leather jacket over it looked awful but would protect against knife cuts in a pinch. She also didn't bring any mugging-enticing bag with her, although Jason knew she had to have her phone on her somewhere since the tracker was pinging her clearly. She even had long pants and good running shoes on, in case she had to try and make a quick exit.

If he didn't know better, he'd guess she has some kind of a bulletproof vest under the clothes. But he knew better and despite all her weirdly knowledgeable preparation, she was still as defenseless as ever. The moment someone notices how out of place she is, she's toast.

What was she even thinking she can do? One talk with a kid in Crime Alley — what would that achieve? Because she certainly *couldn't* be thinking of making this a regular thing. She wasn't *that* mad. On the other side, she *did* move back into Gotham, knowing full well not only that the city is full of her worst triggers, but also that she'll be underemployed. Maybe she *was* that mad.

No, this would be a one-time thing if Jason had anyth—

Oh. Oh god. *Oh fuck. Fuuuuck.*

Of course this would be a one-time thing. Because there never was a plan to have her visit more than once, was there? This was so terribly, obviously, a trap. Why didn't he think about this earlier? What kind of Crime Alley kid would even call her?! If only she wasn't so stubborn, hadn't argued with him, if he hadn't gotten angry at her—...

There was no time to lose. He had to get her out of here, *now*. Before she is too far in.

Jason nervously tapped his fingers on the edge of the roof. If he swoops in, they will make a scene. Bad. In his style, but bad. He does *not* want anyone here to remember her face, especially not associate her with *him*. She has to back out on her own. But she doesn't have any comms...

Or does she?

He pulled out his phone out of the inner pocket of his jacket, took off a glove and tapped her number in.

Ring. Ring. Rin—

"Jay? What's — "

"Listen," he cut her off immediately, and hoped she can understand his street accent because it sure as hell was going to kick in any moment, like always when he was angry and in a rush. "I need ya to turn 'round, *now*."

"What? Why? How do you even know where I am?"

"Course I know. You're in the Crime Alley, exactly where I told ya not to go. I'd know that much even if I didn't have a tracker on you."

"Excuse me? You've been stalking me?"

"No! That's not how it works. Besides, 's not important right now. Go home. Now!"

She sighed as if giving up. Jason regarded it as an at least partial victory.

"...why?"

"S a trap. Yer walkin' right into a kidnapping. You're going to end up trafficked o' harvested for organs o'—"

"Jay. Jay, stop. "

"I won't stop until ya realize—"

"I know. I realize. I knew from the beginning. "

Jason took a moment to pause and blink.

"Ya fuckin' *what*?"

"I know what I'm doing. I'm not five, I don't take candy from strangers anymore. And this was obvious from a mile. The kid sounded fake as hell."

"Then what the fuck are ya doin'?"

His heart couldn't decide between being absolutely, batshit *furios* and completely, overwhelmingly *scared* for her. Maybe he was both, at the same time.

"The kid sounded fake as hell in his scripted dialogue read off a page someone gave him to lure me. Not in what was under it. I heard his trembling voice. He's afraid and alone and needs help."

"An' how the fuck d'ya suppose you're gonna help him?"

"I'm getting him out of here."

He definitely was both at the same time and he did not know how to cope.

"That's not how it works! Yer gonna get shanked! Ya dunno what yer doin'!"

"Guy who started doing flips off criminals' backs at twelve doesn't get to judge me in this matter."

Jason stuttered, just for a brief moment, just for a split second because she *was* a bit right and he *hated* it.

"*I* had Batman t'cover me," he barked back in defense.

"And I wanted to have you at my side," Julianna replied. It sounded more serious and controlled than any words she uttered ever before. Jason didn't think she could speak this... *coldly*. *"But you didn't want to. You wouldn't listen to me at all. You knew better. You threatened violence if I disobeyed. What am I, your Robin?"*

And that, oh, that *stung*. He made an ungodly, angry screech, then threw his phone so hard it hit the wall of the building on the other side of the street and just *exploded* into pieces.

Jason stared at the falling remains of his phone with a blank expression — not the first nor the last time he did that kind of thing in anger — then sighed. "Real mature of you Jay," he mumbled to himself. Somehow, that act of destruction made his anger disappear. Dissipate into thin air, into easily swallowed pieces, just like the ones that were his phone just a moment ago.

He knew why he was suddenly so angry. It was because Juls was goddamn fucking *right*. He acted *exactly* like Bruce did towards them, always treating them like babies. *No, you can't go, you don't know what you're doing, you'll get hurt. I don't want to hear this! You're staying in the Cave!* And then the Robin snuck out anyway and did his goddamn job and saved Batman's life or something, because there was more to the kid than Bruce could ever see. More to Dick, to Jason. To Tim. To Damian. They fucked up, sure, a lot, but they knew what they were capable of, and if Bruce could just *listen* for once...

Jason didn't like this revelation. Jason didn't like how much he apparently acted like Bruce while swearing he's better, different than him. Jason didn't like how this all suggested he saw Juls as a kid that he needed protect, or maybe use and control. But mostly, Jason didn't like the fact that he ruined the exact device he used to track and contact Juls. Because his outburst caused him to lose sight of her. And now he would not only have to push away his unprocessed feelings but also track her without a clue about which way she went. And without a clue if she's still alright.

Fuck. Just — Fuck.

Chapter 3: Red Hood

Chapter Summary

The definition of friendship and affection is a little different than what Bruce taught you, Little wing.

Chapter Notes

For those who did not read previous work in the series: Juls is a metahuman who can see, talk and interact with ghosts.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Luckily, none of them had guns. Juls would probably hyperventilate herself into a coma if three thugs were pointing guns at her. Not that she had more chance of survival against three knives if they knew how to handle those. But at least she had her thick leather jacket, which could stop a slash or two. That would give Jason time to check out the situation and deal with it the best way he could. It was bound to be messy and clumsy, because he couldn't just shoot them and be done with it, not with Juls in the middle of it all. He needed to find a way to take out at least two of them, and hope Juls wouldn't be taken as a hostage by the third before he incapacitated him too. Maybe if he snuck to the other corner? Or dropped from—

Yeah, no. Everything he had planned went out the window in a heartbeat when Juls, instead of stepping back like a normal civilian, stood her ground. Looking like she's about to throw down with the thugs, no less. Did she have any fighting capability, or was she just attempting to scare them away? Jason had to admit, though, she did have *great* intimidation skills for someone as non-threateningly adorable as her.

Staring right at the three men before her, Juls was keeping the teen she came here for behind her with one arm, with the other... it seemed like she was holding something. But there was nothing there. Why was she grasping air?

"Your Ma isn't very proud of how you turned out lately, Graham," she said, looking one of the goons straight in the eyes, brow furrowed. It occurred to Jason that she didn't say it as a question. She didn't even use the past tense. With her tone, it was more like she was relaying a message in real-time than—

Then he noticed it. The vaguely familiar *shift* about her, the slight change in her posture or vibe or *something*. The feeling she gave off when she was dealing with a ghost. When she stared death in the eyes. The feeling that always made Jason think twice about whenever she

was as innocent as she seemed. The three thugs apparently thought so too, judging by how their scowls faltered a bit.

She *was* relaying a message. Jason couldn't help but blink, a little shocked. It all fell into place. She wasn't holding air, she was holding *hands*. With, he assumed, a ghost. A ghost who was probably no-one else than the late mother of the goon she addressed.

Goddamned metas. It was clever, but could she really drive them away by just talking?

The thug she addressed snapped out of his shock and growled at her.

"Ya shut your trap up or I'll cut your tongue out." She didn't seem fazed at first, but Jason could see how she clenched her free hand into a fist nervously.

"She loves you because you are her child. No matter how bad you think about yourself, she will love you. She will love you *because* you think bad about yourself."

His face dropped, and then his arms lowered, mouth trembling like he was about to start crying.

"What, ya think ye can scare us wit' some psych shit that could fit half the country?" a second goon stepped towards her, knife outstretched, sensing she struck a chord with his companion.

"You, on the other hand, just don't want to admit you're *so* like your father," Juls continued without missing a beat. Like she was prepared. "Doing to others what he did to you makes it hurt less. Feels like you're in control."

"You betcha," he grinned, unamused, still advancing. Jason noticed how Juls did everything in her might not to flinch, to keep staring and talking instead.

"It felt freeing, the twenty-three stabs. Sure got a lot out of your system, Charles."

That finally stopped him in his tracks. His other two companions looked at his back with furrowed brows like the fickle trust that guaranteed cooperation between them had been weakened.

"How the fuck would ya know?!" he yelled. The kid behind Juls cowered in fear.

Juls smirked in response. Did her best impression of knowledgeable smirk too, like someone who has control over a situation. Jason could appreciate the performance. He knew it was a performance because he could see the tension in her back, all tight and high-strung.

Then she took a step forward, like an idiot, and Jason immediately went back to trying to figure out how to help her.

"The same way I know how what happened to your brother."

Now that, that was a bullseye. The third goon almost dropped his knife, moving sharply and angrily.

“What did you do to Billie?!” he asked with a low, threatening rumble in his voice, turning to his friend.

Jason knew where this was leading to. Juls seemed to know, too. She was running, dragging the kid with her, before the yelling match even started. Stopped only three blocks down the road, exhausted and panting. Wasn’t too hard for Red Hood to keep up and follow.

He climbed down into a side alley and whistled, getting her attention, then motioned for her to come closer. The moment she recognized him, she almost ran into the shadows.

“Ya okay?” he asked, wrapping his arm around her shoulders for a moment. He could almost feel her heartbeat, that’s how wild it was.

She just nodded vigorously, too out of breath to speak just yet, and pushed him away slightly to lean forward and rest better. Then she turned her attention to the kid, and Jason naturally followed suit. Only then he realized the kid was mortified to see him. Or mortified about what Juls said to those guys. Or just mortified in general, really, that would also be a valid reaction to the whole ordeal.

He pondered he’d be too if he saw something like that go down. Shit had to look *weird* as fuck from the kid’s perspective.

“Don’t worry, it’s going to be okay. We’ll keep you safe,” Juls said when she caught her breath, glancing over to Jason. “He won’t hurt you, I promise.”

The tween didn’t seem convinced, so Juls kneeled in front of him. Gently took the kid’s face in her hands, and turned it towards her, so he would have to stop staring at Jason’s intimidating and slightly annoyed posture. Then she smiled.

“I know you probably didn’t expect this at all, but you’re safe now, okay? They won’t get you.”

“Ya didn’t fuckin’ *ask* him if he even wanted to go with ye?!” Jason exploded hearing that. This entire thing was a *mess*.

Julianna just outstretched a single finger to shush him.

“I’ll get you a warm bed and a meal for tonight, no strings attached, and then we can talk about the future in the morning, okay? I won’t do anything without your consent, I promise.”

Jason forced Juls’ hand down, then squatted next to her, pushing her away from the kid slightly.

“Your promises don’t mean shit right now,” he mumbled to her, then looked up at the tween. “Listen kid, she’s might not know jack shit about us Crime Alley people, but she’s a good person, alright? So at this point you should grab the chance to get a good night’s sleep, a shower and a real, hot meal, and think about running later, mmkay?”

He pulled a candy bar from a pocket of his jacket, then handed it to the silent kid before turning his head to Juls again. “Because she’ll totally understand if ya don’t wanna stay,

right?” he growled slowly through gritted teeth.

She groaned, slightly offended.

“Of course. Don’t worry. I want to help, but I won’t force you to do anything. Alright?”

Jason stood up, satisfied. The kid took a deep breath in, slowly nodding too.

“Alright.” His voice was small and overwhelmed, so he couldn’t be much of a fighter. Jason *could* believe that Juls heard him on the phone and immediately thought he needs help. Because *hell*, you don’t last long on the street if you’re meek like that.

Jay sighed, simply tired of this entire situation.

“Let’s get you somewhere safe now. You two stay put.” He pulled out a small comms earpiece out of his pocket and threw it to Juls. “In case ya need to run. I’ll be right back with my bike.”

She pulled a face at the device in her hands, but nodded, dropping it into an inner pocket.

When the door to the bathroom closed and the noise of running water could be heard, Juls finally let out the breath she was holding. The kid was safe - agreed to stay at her place until morning, scarfed three bowls of chili and now was getting a much-needed warm shower, while a pullout sofa full of pillows and blankets awaited him.

Julianna looked up at Jason, who was leaning on the kitchen door with a sour expression.

“Can we argue tomorrow?” she pleaded softly, her voice sounding way more tired than she looked.

“What?”

“I can see your face. You really want to yell at me.”

He groaned.

“Yeah, okay. Fine. I admit.” She seemed surprised by his words. “There were at least three occasions today when I wanted to rip you a new one. Doesn’t mean I’m gonna do it. What you did was—”

“Can we *talk* tomorrow, then? I’m exhausted. Please.”

Jason sighed and rolled his eyes dramatically. “Sure.”

Julianna dragged herself to the kitchen and downed two big cups of water. Stared at the sink for a moment, then turned to Jason again. Slowly made her way over to him and rested her forehead on his chest without but a word. He stared at her, surprised.

“Uh, Juls?”

“Stay tonight?” she whispered.

“Yeah, alright. I was planning to do so anyway, just in case.” There was an awkward moment of silence between them. “Is everything—”

And then he noticed. Her shoulders shuddering, and the quiet sobs, muffled by his own jacket. She was crying.

“I—” she managed to mumble, “I was so scared. I thought— I’m not gonna make it—”

He looked down at her, confused and lost. What was he supposed to do? This was new and unprecedented. Nobody he knew ever needed to release tension after a mission, not this way, not this kind. Neither heroes nor outlaws wanted to show weakness like this. And even if they did, certainly nobody was looking to *him* for comfort.

“Hey, Juls, calm down. It wasn’t that bad—”

She just started crying harder, her words no longer understandable. Jason bit his lip. Then he did the only thing he knew could possibly be appropriate.

He wrapped his arms around her and hugged.

Every time he wanted to start talking about that night, she hushed him and said “Not now”. She had full-time work and a kid to find a place and care for, and while he could understand why she didn’t want to talk right after, or even the next day, falling silent about it for a whole *week* was just fucking *rude*.

When the kid got into a youth shelter Juls vouched for, under a fake name, she *finally* decided to sit down with him and talk. He was in a very foul mood for a few days then, and couldn’t help but tap his foot in irritation at that point.

“I see the princess decided to grace me with an audience,” he said sarcastically, glaring at her.

Julianna just sighed and sat down with her cup. The coffeeshop was pretty empty, and their spot secluded enough to talk. Soft music in the background didn’t really fit the atmosphere between them.

“You have every right to be upset with me,” she started, and Jason could already hear all the excuses and ‘buts’ in his head. “Thank you for being patient and giving me time to process what happened, even when you really wanted to talk.”

He blinked. What was she *on* about?

“And I’m sorry. I should have never spoken to you like that, I should have not poked at things that cut you deep. Being stressed is no excuse for hurting you. I hope I can make it up

to you one day. I promise I will do my best to never do it again.”

Jason held out his hands to stop her, shaking his head in disbelief.

“You think *that’s* what I’m angry about?”

She shook her head.

“You’re also angry I went at all.”

“Well, duh! You could’ve gotten yourself killed!”

For a moment, she didn’t answer, playing with the cup ear of her coffee instead.

“I know. All the more reason to be thankful you were there for me even when you were angry, even after I was mean to you. Hopefully next time, you won’t have to.”

“*Next time* ?! There’s not going to *be* a next time!” he stood up from the table, placing his hands on it with a loud thud. The barista looked at Juls as if checking in if everything is alright, and she nodded with an apologetic expression. Jason sat down, knowing he shouldn’t make a scene.

“Jason. Please. Listen to me. I’m going to sound a little like a shrink, but I did study psych and it’s hard not to look at things like that.”

He growled half-heartedly, but allowed her to continue.

“I’m a civilian who knows absolutely nothing about crime and fighting and survival. I will get myself into trouble because I’m weak and sheltered and would not survive the winter. You dislike that. You want to keep me out of trouble. And it’s because you’re, I hope, worried for me, and would rather see me safe and sound. But you’re worried for me like I was a *child*. A puppy that’s going to run into traffic. A baby bird that fell out of its nest—”

Jason opened his mouth to protest, but she shushed him with a quick gesture.

“— but the truth is, weak and unfit for the streets I might be, I’m not *helpless*. I’m an adult, I can care for myself. In many things I can handle myself better than you. In many things, you’re superior. That’s because we’re two different people. But neither one of us is better *overall*. Neither of us gets to control the other! I recognize the things in which I *suck* and I came to you for help with them. I thought we could achieve something together. Better. Safer. Compliment each other’s strengths. But maybe you value your fortes more than mine, because what you did was ignore my areas of expertise — didn’t even bother understanding where I was coming from — and tried to do the entire thing *your way*, and your way *only*. And I wouldn’t have that. And it made you angry. And for that, I will *not* apologise. This one is *not* on me.”

Halfway through her monologue, he started tapping his fingers on the table in irritation. He wasn’t dumb. He could see when someone was *right*. Didn’t mean he was going to be happy about it.

“I’m my own *person*, Jay, not an extension of yourself. I get to have my own agenda. I deserve respect. I should be heard out. And so do you. God, *so do you*. Please, understand that.”

Julianna sighed, and fell silent for a good while. Sipped her coffee until she ran out, then looked back at his annoyed, darkened face.

“Do you want me to go away?”

He grimaced. “No.”

Her shoulders visibly relaxed. Only then he noticed how tense she was the entire time she talked. Like he was going to have another outburst and yell at her any moment. Maybe start throwing shit. Maybe get a little violent. And honestly? He could totally see himself doing that. He almost did.

Something cold and unpleasant sank in his stomach when he realized she was, at least a bit, afraid of him.

“I have a lot to think about,” Jason said slowly, brows still furrowed. Juls put her hand on his gently.

“I’m going to be here if you need me. That’s what friends are for.”

Chapter End Notes

Forgive me for having no idea how to write bad guys.

Chapter 4: Little Wing

Chapter Summary

Jason finds solutions in cooperation.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

“Macbeth again, huh?”

Jason looked up at Juls, and put the book away for a moment to grab the beer she was holding out for him.

“What can I say. Classics never get old.”

She put a small bowl of cashews on the coffee table and set herself on the couch next to him, with a book of her own. Hers was a medical book, though, not fiction. “Comfort book much?”

“Yeah, reading about how someone else fucks up their life big-time like an absolute idiot always make me feel better about myself,” he took a gulp from the bottle, then made an approving noise and looked at the label. “New one. What gives?”

“Found a fancy craft beer shop down the road. Like it?”

“Yeah. Add it to the Jason-approved list of offerings.”

“Duly noted.”

Jason eyed her for a moment. “I’m still angry at you, though.”

“I am aware of that. I’m also aware that there’s nothing I can do about it. Or *should* do about it.”

“Except maybe bringing me good beer.”

Juls grinned. “Except bringing you good beer. And snacks,” she added, offering him her bowl of cashews. He grabbed a few and returned to the three witches and their prophecy for a long while.

Slow afternoons like that had evolved from Tuesday lunches and Sunday Netflix nights. They would read next to each other or watch something together, and chat and sometimes order pizza, but there was tension between them. Tension that Jason knew is his anger. But he

didn't want to let go. Didn't want to admit to it, because admitting to it would be also agreeing she was right. And that he maybe should do something about it.

So he was silent, pretending everything was normal, and so was she, and sometimes he forgot what the fuss was about. But periodically he'd remind her they weren't all good. He reminded himself they weren't all good. He wasn't all good.

And he hated it.

Jason mulled over his thoughts, staring at the same page for a good five minutes. Juls must've noticed it, because she sent him worried glances from time to time, before finally speaking up.

"You okay?"

He slapped his book shut and put it down on the table, then energetically turned around on the couch. Sitting sideways to face her, Jason tried to figure out a way to say what he had in mind.

"I got an idea."

Jul raised her eyebrows quizzically, then bookmarked and closed her book too.

"I'm listening."

"I'm going to teach you self-defense."

She nodded, remaining silent as if waiting for the continuation. When he didn't pick up, she tried to pry more out of him with a simple "Okay?"

"You know. So you'll know how to defend yourself at least a bit."

She smirked. "So you won't have to stalk me out of worry?"

Jason shrugged and made a nondescript, slightly offended noise, but it was obvious that's exactly what he meant. At least the worrying part. The ~~stalking~~ tracking would remain if he could help it.

"Do you mean self-defense as in how to get free from a wrestling hold, or as in I'm-going-to-show-you-how-to-deck-a-grown-man?"

"Street smarts. What to avoid, how not to look like an easy target, what you can do when things go south even if you're smaller. Things you'd have learned as a teen if you were slightly less of a sheltered princess."

Juls chuckled. "Yeah we've done this before, I'm already only half as sheltered as I used to be in my teens."

He rolled his eyes. Sometimes it was annoying when she referenced their shared past that he remembered nothing of. But he learned to roll with it - what was the point arguing with it?

She didn't seem the type to make stuff up, and even if she occasionally did, the things she said weren't improbable enough for him to notice. And he *did* allow her to refer to him as the same Jason that she used to know, so he wasn't really in the spot to complain now.

Not that it would stop him from picking up where she left it and teasing her about it.

"Jeez, being around you must've felt like babysitting," Jay said with a shit-eating grin. She didn't seem to take the bait, challenging him a bit instead.

"That's one of the things you always seemed to complain about, yeah," she laughed. "The same as I always complained that you're a little shit."

"Not so little anymore," he stood up briskly and flexed one of his arms in an overly dramatic manner, making her giggle.

"Yeah, I miss the time when you were an entire head shorter than me."

"Maybe if you stood on the table, sure."

They shared a hearty laugh. For a moment, it seemed like their argument was but water under the bridge. Jason wished it was like that.

"Okay," Juls finally said when she caught a breath. "I agree to your offer. Under one condition."

"I'm listening," he mimicked her tone and pose from a moment before, mocking her a little and getting a small smirk out of her.

"If you're going to teach me something, I'm going to teach you something too."

Uh-oh.

"What? Teach me what?"

"To be a decent human being," she replied, with a shit-eating grin of her own. Jason groaned and dramatically fell back onto the couch as if she dealt him a lethal blow. "I'm going to learn how to punch things if you learn how to talk about your emotions. That's my deal."

He could get irritated. He could yell how he doesn't want to, how he doesn't need to, how it's stupid. He could refuse her suggestion, insist that it's pointless, that he doesn't need to learn anything like that. Stand up and leave. Have another shitty, quiet, lonely day, week or month. He could do many things, and all of them would be very Jason "Red Hood" Todd of him.

So he did the one that would have more of a Jason "Little wing" Todd vibe.

"Fine! But I'm going to complain the entire time."

She chuckled. "Yeah, I expected nothing less from you."

The first few times they've met for *lessons* were unbelievably boring and irritating, for both of them. She *sucked* at anything physical, because the last time she exercised was probably in a past life. He would rather *die again* than talk to her about why he was constantly so goddamn angry.

And yet, they persevered. Mostly because Juls tried her damn *best*, even if it meant she was laying on the floor for half an hour trying to catch a breath and looking like she just got slammed by a truck. That made him feel very fucking *guilty* every time he thought of setting the notes she gave him on fire. So they persevered.

Jason wouldn't say he *enjoyed* any moment of noting down words for emotions and how people dealt with them and what's the definition of a coping mechanism. But he *was* pretty stoked to see that over those weeks Juls' hits were getting better, and that on one particularly good day and with a bit of luck she even floored him with a well-aimed kick to the knee.

"Oh my god, are you okay?" she gasped and jumped to him when he bent over in pain.

"I'm fine, it takes way more than that to get me," he mumbled, massaging the sore spot above his knee. "That was good. Keep that up."

Juls grinned.

"How that makes you feel?"

Jason rolled his eyes, then smirked. "Proud. Damn heckin' proud."

She jumped in a little victory gesture.

"The feeling's mutual," she said, offering him a hand to help him stand up. He grabbed it and pulled himself up, nearly toppling her over with his weight. "I think it's a good moment to take a break. My shift starts in two hours, and I'd like to shower and grab some lunch before it."

"Fair. Thai takeout to celebrate your first takedown?" he grinned.

"Only if it's on you, I'm knee-deep in student debt and can't go over budget."

He made a mental note to somehow use his stupid amount of ~~slightly~~ *very illegal* money to pay her debts off.

"Of course it's on me! Gentlemen always pay."

"I'd call you many things, Jay, but a *gentle* man is not one of them."

"Touché."

"You're still paying."

He burst into laughter. "Hit the shower and meet me by my bike down the street in fifteen, sounds okay? And yes I have a spare helmet for you this time."

“Who’s the mind-reader now?” she replied with a grin of her own. Jason just sighed and left, shaking his head and smiling.

In time their little exchange of knowledge started to gain traction. To the point where Jason pondered dropping by Dick’s apartment to just... talk, like humans. Like brothers. Like they used to. He hadn’t acted on the urge, but it was there, nagging, reminding of itself constantly. Sometimes like a mysterious longing in his heart. Sometimes like a bad spicy taco in his guts.

The lessons also gained traction on Juls side. To the point where she dared to ask him, albeit meekly, for help in checking up on a patient they lately had in the hospital, one that lived in Park Row. Jason just rolled his eyes at her and sighed. And gave her a ride.

To some degree that was, in retrospect, a mistake. Because even though it went smoothly and this time it was not a trap (he made sure beforehand), it encouraged her. With his support and the little training she had, she got *bold*. Started asking him to escort her into Crime Alley more often. In a flash, she had ten different kids talking to her on the reg. Small ones, who didn’t harden enough to scoff at offers of help yet, sometimes their siblings, curious about the changes they saw. They got a fucking entire *therapy group* there. And Jason couldn’t just *stop* helping her run it.

Not that he’d want to, he mused. He thought he *should* want it to stop. So he didn’t have obligations like this. So he wasn’t involved in something this... this... soft. But he didn’t. He didn’t mind. He liked it.

Jason remembered he enjoyed helping. Not beating people up, not keeping criminals in check, not dominating over the bad guys. At the core, he wanted the people of Gotham, the people of Crime Alley, to have it better. To have food and shelter and safety. And apparently therapy, if they needed.

He remembered he used to be Robin, the morality pet — however badly warped his own morality was — who cared about people, first and foremost. Not Batman, the caped crusader, who always put the mission first.

Those were the thoughts that filled his mind as they were preparing to leave Crime Alley for the day, having had just left the ruined building Juls had made into a makeshift psych centre. Those were the thoughts that came to a screeching halt when he saw a gun pointed at Juls out of the corner of his eye. His instincts kicked in, and he immediately tackled her into the wall behind her, then pushed her back into the building. She only managed to let out a startled gasp, air knocked out of her lungs.

He didn’t ask them questions. He decided he would figure it out later. Priority was taking these guys down.

Not that it was hard. He peeked out from behind the door and planted a few well-aimed bullets in their legs. Some began to crawl away in panic, possibly not prepared for any kind of retribution. Those who didn’t got a quick kick to the head to make sure they wouldn’t try anything stupid. He would ask them questions later. Figure out what this was about. For now,

he dragged one of the unconscious men back into the building. Dropped him right next to the door, then went to check up on Juls. She was pale, but present, curled into a ball in the corner, cowering. He walked up and squatted next to her, obscuring the bandit from her view.

“It’s okay. It’s safe now.” Jason put a hand on her shoulder and squeezed gently. She nodded and smiled weakly.

“I’m good.”

“Now listen carefully,” he began, slowly, sternly. “And don’t panic.”

“Okay, yeah, that’s definitely gonna make me panic. What’s happening?”

“Seems like someone sent hired thugs after us.”

“W-what? Why would anyone—?”

“I’ve got some ideas. Maybe someone didn’t like our little therapy group. Maybe they were after me, though that would mean their employer is dense like a brick. I’ll have to find out.”

Juls nodded again. After a brief pause looked hesitantly at the door. “Is it safe to —?”

Jason grimaced, then shrugged.

“Should be, but I’m not sure. Gotta squeeze some answers from that guy over there,” he motioned towards the unconscious thug

“I’m not keen on watching you beat information out of people,” she mumbled.

“Yeah, I realize. But if I leave that guy to get you to safety, he absolutely won’t be here later.”

“I’m also not really keen on going out into ‘ *I’m not sure if it’s safe* ’ alone.”

“Oh, no, I’m not letting you go out there alone, not in a million years,” he immediately retorted. Then he sat down next to her, hand still on her shoulder reassuringly. “But I can’t be in two places at once.”

“Maybe— Maybe the kids? I mean, they know how to get around, right? I bet Jimmy would —”

He put up his hand to stop her.

“As much as I know these kids genuinely like and appreciate you, Juls, they have two major flaws that make this idea absolute crap. Sure, they could try to lead you out into midtown via their secret little safe passages. But one, they grew up in this dump and however much they like you, the moment there’s danger it’s every person for themselves. And there *will* be danger. Two, even if any of them decided to defend you, none of them is big enough to make a difference. I mean, they’re like, ten years old max. What do you expect them to do? Throw a rock at a gunman?”

Juls sighed in silent defeat. Jason tapped his fingers nervously on his knees. He needed ideas. He needed a plan. He needed *backup*.

His eyes widened and he turned to Juls enthusiastically.

“Hey. Do you trust me?”

She seemed caught off-guard by that question.

“Yes? But that is a very suspicious-sounding question to ask in this situation.”

He grinned, glad that his mischievous reputation still stands. “Would you trust people that *I* trust?”

Juls blinked. “I thought you worked alone?”

“Usually. Wasn’t always the case, right? I think I can pull a few strings and get someone else to cover you while I deal with this mess.”

She raised her eyebrows.

“Please tell me you’re not going to call Batman.”

Jason choked on his spit. “Ew, no. I’d rather die than ask *him* for help.”

Julianna mulled over her answer for a moment in silence. Then, she nodded. “Yeah. I think I could trust your friends. Thank you for asking first, too.”

“I’m diligently doing my homework,” he grinned and pulled out his phone and dialed the only person who he knew would be up for babysitting a civilian for some time.

“Hey, ‘Wing. Do I have any favors with you I could cash in?”

Chapter End Notes

Happy new year! :)

Chapter 5: Nightwing

Chapter Summary

Big brother fills in for when Jason is busy.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

He swooped in on the coords as fast as he could, because Jason sounded *angry* and weirdly *cold* when he relayed his need for backup. That was a dangerous mix, especially with civilians involved.

Jason just nodded when he saw him and took off, dragging an unconscious thug with him, without even a word of debrief. Dick sighed and shook his head.

“I will need to ask you what was that all about,” he said to the only other person in the vicinity, the girl he was supposed to take to safety on behalf of Red Hood, “but I’m told it’s not very safe for you here, huh?”

She nodded, waving him a little hello. He responded with a smile and a wave of his own.

Plain clothes, chubby tummy and cheeks, hair in a high ponytail. Pale, scared face. Perfectly ordinary, but also awkwardly out of place anywhere south of Mayfair avenue.

“My car’s not that far,” he said, motioning for her to come closer, and she obediently did, “but I guess maybe you shouldn’t be seen strutting down the road with a vigilante if we want to keep your profile low,” he added, pulling out his grappling gun.

“You have to be kidding me,” she immediately took a tiny step back and pointed broadly to her plump figure. “You can’t hope to carry me.”

“Don’t worry, these muscles aren’t just for show,” he grinned, patting one of his biceps.

She nodded hesitantly, though her face screamed disbelief. He led her towards a hole in the wall opening into a secluded alley.

“This is going to be a little awkward. Wrap your arms around my neck as tight as you can, and I’ll secure you by your waist. I promise you’ll be safe,” he flashed her one of his signature reassuring, bright smiles.

She sighed in defeat.

“So, the name’s Nightwing,” he said the moment they both got into his *Nightcar*, currently camouflaged as a plain, black Toyota. Man, he really needed to stop using that name, *Nightcar* sounded ridiculous. But at the same time, there was something *sentimental* about it. Reminded him of simpler times, when he would name everything Bat-something, when Bruce would be caring and kind in his own, weird way, and Jason was a cute, eager teen with a filthy mouth.

He pushed those thoughts away and extended his right hand to her as she fumbled with her seatbelt.

“Julianna Powell,” she answered, squeezing his hand. He blinked a few times. Where did he hear that name before...?

Dick’s eyes flashed with recognition and he laughed.

“Oh. Oh my god! What a coincidence! You’re the ghost girl that gave her number to Hood!”

She rolled her eyes, but her cheeks turned red a bit.

“I’m glad Jay speaks well of me. Tho ‘ghost girl’ isn’t exactly how I hoped I’d be referred to.”

“How, then?”

“By my name would be fine.”

“Well, Julie, mind telling me what happened there that Jaybird so desperately needed help?”

She shrugged. “Not entirely sure. Someone shot at us out of the blue. He’s trying to figure out who and why now. And since I’m a big baby when it comes to danger, he doesn’t let me wander Crime Alley alone.”

“Wait,” he put his hands on the wheel as if to ground himself and looked her straight in the eyes. “You’re telling me you two keep in touch?”

“Uh, yea? We—... wait. He didn’t tell you anything, did he?” she eyed him. “If Jay didn’t tell you about me, it probably is for a reason. I mean, he failed to mention he keeps in touch with you, too.”

Dick pouted dramatically, then sighed with a smile. “Fair. Admirable loyalty and impressive acumen. He just told me the ‘issue’ with his secret identity being compromised was ‘*handled*,’” she raised her eyebrows in a clearly ‘*wow rude*’ grimace at the fact that she was being called an ‘issue’. “Jay and I... We... used to be closer. He’s not a people person these days.”

Juls smirked. “He is, if you give him time.”

Dick was about to try to press a little further to understand what she meant exactly, but then his comms beeped.

“‘Wing, do you copy?’”

He tuned into his comms, leaning away from Julianna instinctively. “What’s up, Hood?”

“*This is bigger than I thought, mafia’s involved. Quite the mess. Gotta track a few people and remind them who’s boss in these parts. Don’t ride to her home, get her somewhere secure. And keep an eye on her for a few days, will you?*”

“What do you mean, a few days? I’ll gladly help you but what am I supposed to do with her if I can’t deliver her home?”

“*I don’t know, you come up with something, Goldenboy. Hood out.*”

“Jay—!”

Dick looked at her, a little sad, a little confused, fully apologetic. Juls shrugged.

“We’ll have to find a nice little place to stash you for a while.”

“Wait, like I just have to not show up at my place, or like I can’t show my face outside at all?”

“The latter, I’m afraid,” he sighed.

“You know that I have full-time work I can’t just... *disappear* from,” she stated. He nodded slowly. He only vaguely remembered where she worked — some kind of hospital — but he was pretty sure he could get Babs to put in a fake sick leave in their system. Or he’ll just strut in there as officer Grayson and say she’s a witness or something.

“That’s not really the problem here.”

She didn’t seem convinced but also didn’t argue with him.

“If you can figure out how to not get me fired while I’m missing shifts, I’m sure my mom or my brother would let me crash for a few nights.”

“I doubt they count as *secure* in Jaybird’s mind. Does any of them have a home security system?”

“No? So wha—”

Dick groaned. With mafia involved, he couldn’t just drop her at her someone’s doorstep. They’d find her sooner or later, and if anything happened to her, Jason would *have his head* for sure.

“So no, they definitely do not count as *secure* .”

“Well, then, I’m out of ideas,” she fell back against the seat. “I’m not Jay to have like a dozen different places all over the city to drop in at a whim.”

Dick grinned, her words giving him an idea. Possibly not a good one, mind you, but at least *an* idea.

“You’re not. But *I* am.”

As he opened the door for her and let her in, her face went from a little confused to outright *amazed*. Dick liked it when people beamed like that, like they just saw something breathtaking. He turned on the wall lights in the living area. She walked into the room and turned around full circle, taking her surroundings in, all starry-eyed.

“This— this is your *safehouse* ? Like something that you rarely use, and keep *just in case* ?”

On second thought, it was kind of sad that she was this blown away by a nice apartment. It always was sad when he realized how much of a difference was between them — between *him* — and normal people of Gotham.

It was no use mulling over it, not at that moment, no. Dick walked in after her.

“*Technically* it’s Batman’s but he won’t mind,” he grinned playfully, then vaulted over the couch to sit on it, his legs landing on the coffee table gracefully and gently. “Not every one of them is like this. I picked out the nicest one for you. You’re going to be home-arrested in here for some time, after all.”

“You do realize this is bigger than any place I’ve ever lived in, right?”

“The job has its perks,” Dick laughed, and soon after she followed suit. For a moment her laugh was a little awkward, a little hysterical. But it quickly morphed into a genuine one. Their laughs matched, brisk and bright and sincere in tone, and it only made Dick smile more.

When they finally stopped laughing, she sat next to him on the couch.

“What now? You’re just going to go home?”

“I was thinking I’ll stay for a while, make sure it’s safe, nobody followed us or anything. Give you a tour around here maybe,” he winked. “Get to know you, too. I mean, you must be one hell of a person if you befriended Jaybird.”

Julianna smiled a little, accepting the compliment wordlessly.

“He’s a difficult man, true. But I’m used to people like that.”

“Oh?”

“I’m a psychologist. My entire life is devoted to helping people who might not even know they need help.”

He tilted his head, looking at her. “But you weren’t a psychologist back when you met him, right?”

“Back when I met him?” she parroted in confusion.

“I know the ghost girl story, remember? I know you met him back when—” he missed a beat, and for a split second his smile faltered. He never liked to talk about it. “— when he was dead.”

Julianna put her hand on his knee. Even though Dick wasn’t used to people doing that (not with how his family was), he *was* a very *tactile* person so he leaned into the reassuring touch. “He talked about you a lot. You were like a big brother to him.”

“And I let him down,” he sighed.

“If we blame ourselves for every bad thing that happens to our loved ones, we will drown in self-hate and never know peace.”

They stayed in silence for a while, her hand on his knee in a gesture of solidarity.

“What is it like?” he asked finally, not looking up at her. “To see ghosts.”

She let out a long breath like it was a difficult question. He realized it was.

“Very similar to being a psychologist,” she began with a small tease heard in her voice, like she was trying to lighten the mood. She succeeded, a bit. “And very similar to being a hero, I’d guess. It’s a lot. It feels like you’re the only person who can help them. Because you sometimes *are*. And nevertheless, you have to learn that you *can’t* save everyone.”

Dick finally stopped staring at his feet. “But you have to try.”

Julianna nodded. “But you have to try,” she repeated.

He smiled, and let out a sigh, releasing the thoughts that troubled him. “I like you.”

“I was told I’m quite likable. We seem to share that trait.”

Dick chuckled. “I can’t believe someone as tender-hearted as you can stand Jason.”

“Well, that attitude is probably half the reason why he doesn’t seem to be able to stand *you*,” she grinned teasingly.

He dramatically put his hand on his collarbone as if he was clutching a pearl necklace. “Excuse me? I’m his favorite vigilante.”

“Sorry, no, that would be Arsenal.”

“Fair point. I’m way too cuddly for Jaybird,” Dick grinned teasingly, then leaned away and rolled over the armrest. With a little push, he was soon standing upright. “So, interested in that tour?”

“Is there anything here I shouldn’t touch?”

“Oh, plenty. Most off-limits things are electronically locked, though, so don’t worry,” he nodded at her to follow him, and led them into the hall again. “That’s the bedroom, all yours. There should be extra blankets and pillows in the closet. I’m *pretty* sure they should be fairly *fresh*,” he joked.

“Are they silken, at least?” she responded with a tease of her own.

“Who do you take me for, a peasant? Only the finest cashmere.”

They shared a laugh, and Dick walked into the kitchen. He jumped onto the counter and sat on it cross-legged, like the restless monkey that he was. “Hungry?”

“Not really, but I’m betting you have something stupid like caviar here. I’m dying to see what snacks rich boys in Halloween suits eat.”

He chuckled. “You know, *Halloween costume* is possibly the most overplayed joke I’ve heard about it.”

“You want me to call it a fursuit? Is that what you want?”

Dick burst into laughter. “Okay, fine, I admit my defeat. Please stick to calling me a Halloween rich boy.”

Julianna grinned smugly, walked over to one of the cabinets, opened it and started going through its contents.

“Mostly protein and candy bars,” she said with a joking disappointment in her voice. “And a bountiful supply of... Fruity Oat Bits?” She hesitantly pulled a cereal box out of the cupboard, then looked at him with a confused expression. Dick’s face started beaming with childish joy.

“My favorite! I didn’t know we had ‘em here,” he immediately swiped the box out of her hand, and with one quick jump landed next to the fridge, rummaging for milk. “Can you grab me a bowl? It should be in the cupboard on the right.”

Julianna tried not to laugh, but failed miserably. Choking on giggles, she found a bowl and handed it to him just about when he managed to open the milk and get himself a spoon.

Then she started full-on laughing. Literally bent over on the floor, trying to catch a breath. He had to agree with her. There was something *ridiculous* about Nightwing, a vigilante made of lean muscle and bright smiles, standing in the middle of a kitchen, in the dead of night, scarfing down a bowl of kids’ cereal.

He grinned between spoonfuls. “Now this is what I call aster.”

She looked up at him, trying to stop chuckling. “Huh?”

“Aster. Like *disaster*, but without the *dis*.”

“That’s not a word.”

“Well it should be, so I made it so.”

Julianna snorted. “How do people ever take you seriously?”

He stuck out his tongue at her. “They usually don’t. They usually also regret it immensely. As I said, these muscles aren’t *just* for show.”

“But they’re *also* for show, huh?”

“Oh *absolutely!*” Dick grinned and immediately put the bowl down. He rushed into the hall, where there was a little more space, and did a somersault, then a backflip, then stood on his arms.

She gave him an astonished thumbs up. “When did you pick gymnastics up? You seem experienced.”

“I did acrobatics for as long as I remember,” he said, smoothly transitioning to a backbend.

“God, you must’ve been an *insufferable* kid.”

“I was definitely an insufferable *Robin*.”

She snorted again.

“I can imagine. Now the mental image of Batman telling you not to do flips on the roof of the Batmobile will never leave me.”

He laughed, and gracefully returned to standing upright.

“Though aren’t most Robins like that?” Julianna added. “It’s like a trademark, isn’t it. For you to be obnoxious and annoying.”

“Don’t tell that to the current one,” Dick chuckled. “Speaking of which. I should probably get going, or he’s gonna skin me alive. You’re going to be fine?”

“Yeah, I guess so. Can I ask you a favor?”

“Oh boy. People want a lot of favors from me today.”

“A small one, I promise.”

“Okay then. What is it?”

Julianna reached into her pocket and pulled out a ring of keys. She extended her arm, offering it to Dick.

“Could you drop by my place sometime tomorrow and like, grab me my toothbrush, a change of clothes and maybe my cell charger? I’m assuming you know where I live, you are all stalkers.”

He chuckled and grabbed the keys. “Yeah, sure, you got it. I didn’t think about it, honestly. There should be some T-shirts in the bedroom you can use as pajamas for now.”

“Thanks.”

“No problem. Good night!”

She waved at him as he approached the window to leave like a real vigilante.

“You too, Nightwing. It was a pleasure to meet you.”

“Right back at you, Julie.”

Chapter End Notes

How am I pumping out an average of 2k words per day? We just don't know.

P.S. When I said this is going to have 10 chapters I thought Jason is going to take 1 or 2. So like. Uh.

Chapter 6: Nightwing/Boy Wonder

Chapter Summary

Nightwing learns the night doesn't need to be dark and full of terrors.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

He knocked on the glass of the window.

“Hey, are you decent?” he asked loudly towards the inside.

“Not according to my mother, but yeah I’m dressed if that’s what you’re asking!” could be heard from the living room.

Nightwing laughed, typed in the access code and slipped into the apartment. Julie was sitting on the couch, mindlessly staring at a nature documentary on the TV. She smiled at him and waved, and he reciprocated. It was starting to be their usual welcome, and honestly, he could get behind it. Nobody else except other vigilantes was this nonchalantly easygoing towards Nightwing. It was refreshing to see a civilian react to him just like to another human being.

“I see you’re slowly absorbing Jay’s sass,” he said, setting a duffel bag on the coffee table.

“Hopefully he will absorb some of my manners.”

He snorted. “Has he contacted you?”

“Yeah, made sure I’m safe and told me not to call him in case he was ‘*in the middle of business*’,” she smiled with a fake-sour expression, rolling her eyes. “He keeps replying to my texts though, so I know he’s okay, too.”

Nightwing nodded, glad to hear that she cared about Jason at least as much as Jason seemed to care about her. Then he pointed towards the bag.

“Clothes, charger, toothbrush, your entire underwear drawer, the book from your nightstand, the Switch from your living room and all the Switch games I could find.”

She raised her eyebrows. “I should say something like *wow* or *thanks a lot* or *you’re so thoughtful*, but what I really need to say is — my *entire underwear drawer*?”

He shrugged, smiling sheepishly. “It was that or me going through your panties to choose a couple to bring you. I decided just tossing everything into the bag was less creepy.”

“Fair judgement,” she chuckled a bit. Nightwing handed her keys back to her. “I appreciate the console. I am *bored out of my mind* and I was wondering how much I’m going to survive locked up in here.”

“A busy bee, huh?”

“A people person, more like it. I’m not used to being isolated.”

“I thought you were a loner back in school?”

Julie eyed him, a little suspiciously. “And how would you know that?”

Nightwing laughed awkwardly, rubbing the back of his neck. “We did a background check on you back when you first met Jay.”

She rolled her eyes and groaned playfully. “Compulsive stalkers, all of you.”

He fell onto the couch and sat next to her, chuckling under his breath in amusement. “I think your master’s thesis was cool, if that helps.”

Julie turned the sound off on the TV and looked at him, wide-eyed.

“You read it?”

“Skimmed through it. Can’t say I understood much of the psych jargon, really, but I can say with full conviction that your take on grief is really good. Hit close to home, to be honest.”

She smiled sadly at him, and, once again, put her hand on his knee for a moment. “One learns a thing or two about that when they deal with death all their life.”

Nightwing nodded, agreeing in silence, and then it hit him how that sentence wasn’t just about her and her metapower. He froze for a split second. Her observation skills were good, and her ability to notice his long-forgotten emotions was... unsettling, to say the least. His Bat-paranoia spiked at the realization. But if Jay trusted her...

He grinned, like he usually did instead of sighing.

“That’s just how it is when you’re a vigilante. I got used to it,” he said with a shrug.

“That’s possibly the saddest thing one can hear from someone,” she riposted. “*I got used to it. My heart dies a little every time I hear that. My dad beats us, but not very often, so it’s okay, I got used to it. Or I’m constantly hungry, but it doesn’t bother me much, I got used to it. Or I’ve seen so many people die on the streets that I lost count. I got used to it by now. It’s just... wrong.*”

Nightwing furrowed his brows for a moment, making himself more comfortable on the sofa. He didn’t quite like the direction this was going.

“It’s not—”

“— *like that, you don't understand. My situation is different,* ” she interrupted and finished his sentence. One would usually expect this to be accompanied by a sarcastic tone and a smug glance, but her face was the same as before. Soft and sad.

He definitely didn't like the direction this was going. Sure, he was always the one to *give* emotional and passionate motivational speeches, but he wasn't keen on being on the *receiving end* of them. And it was bound to end with one.

Trying to lighten the mood a bit (or maybe derail the conversation), he touched his chin and made a 'hmmm' sound with a playful smirk on his lips.

“And here I thought I already knew who's the World's Greatest Detective.”

“I know human psyche like you know acrobatics, Nightwing,” she seemed a little offended with his comment. “So I'll keep pointing out every time you fall directly into the most stereotypical phrases and scenarios that all psychologists have heard before.”

Nightwing rolled his eyes with an exasperated sigh. He just *loved* when people acted like they knew him.

“Well, what would you suppose I should do instead? Do you maybe have a manual for these things?” he said, sounding a little more sarcastic than he intended to. She winced. He must've hit a weak spot with that. He wasn't sure if he's proud of it, though.

But Julie toughened up and replied.

“Yeah, actually. That is literally what psychology is. A manual for the mind. And it says letting yourself experience grief is key to stop it from controlling your life. Just like with pretty much every emotion.”

He groaned, a little tired of her pushing it. It's not like she wasn't making some sense. But he didn't feel like they're... *close* enough to discuss these things. She wasn't his friend, not yet maybe?, and she certainly wasn't his therapist. Jay's friend or not, he wasn't going to discuss any of his emotions with her. Let alone his vigilante-related turmoil.

“I know you literally just met me and strangers aren't really supposed to talk about these things,” she said, and he pondered for a moment if they're absolutely *sure* she is not a mind reader. “I just hate to see someone as kind as you crumble under pressure because he thinks nobody can help him carry his burdens, and he insists to carry *all* of the burdens.”

Nightwing leaned back, creating some distance between them, and freeing his knee from under her hand. She responded by backing her arm out, giving him the space he wordlessly requested. *Demanded*.

“And how would you know I'm doing that, World's Greatest Psychologist?” he snarked again, hoping she'd get the hint. If she did, she ignored it completely.

“Do you want a heartfelt response, or a technical one?”

“Give me an honest one,” he gave up, leaning even further back into the couch.

Julie took a deep breath, and stayed silent for a moment, seemingly gathering her thoughts.

“You’re the oldest sibling in a group of vigilantes that clearly has family dynamics,” she began, matter-of-factly. Nightwing couldn’t really deny this one. It was common knowledge for Gothamites at this point. “The father figure, Batman, is aloof and emotionally absent, and yet, you are kind and helpful and forever cheerful, even when admitting you’ve seen people die and that it left a mark on you.”

She glanced at him, as if waiting for a confirmation or a denial. He didn’t give her either, but knew there was no lie her words. There was also nothing about his supposed inability to deal with his own issues, though. What was wrong with being cheerful despite challenges?

“You picked up the role of a mascot to make life easier for everybody else and help yourself push away things you didn’t want to think about. Your entire life since you became Robin consists of performing emotional labor for everybody, and if what I vaguely read and heard about you is true, you also command other heroes in and out of battle, taking up the role of a leader, of someone responsible for the outcome of your joint efforts. You’re, functionally, a single parent with a dozen dependent kids and at least one other adult to care for, all while maintaining the equivalent of two full-time jobs in a high-stress environment.”

Now, this one, while not technically *false*, was plenty *overdramatic* and painted with a rather *broad* stroke. He was managing *great*, thank you very much. He was on top of his game of keeping Blüdhaven clean, assisting in Gotham, making sure the Bats don’t kill each other by checking up every so often on Tim, Damian, Bruce, Cass, Steph, Duke and sometimes even Jason, his daily job at BlüDPD, keeping up with the myriad of his friends and colleagues (he made a mental note to call Wally soon, and to send a birthday present to Lian before the end of the month), occasional missions with the Justice League or Titans, especially in the past... Okay, maybe there was something to the ‘two full-time jobs in a high-stress environment’ thing that made some sense. Maybe he had a lot on his plate. So what?

And at that thought, his eyebrows involuntarily slid up. Sure, nothing in her little speech suggested she knew more than a civvie with access to the news would know, and yet. Nightwing still felt like she knew, or rather *understood* more than she should’ve. Because she understood more than *him*. What was her secret to that? Could it be just psychology? Was he giving out so much with his stance and behaviour? Or did Jason compromise him? Would Jason even *know* these things?

A single pang of anger flashed in his mind at that possibility, but faded as fast as it appeared. It was hard to believe his brother, being the secretive ass that he was, would tell on him this much; especially when he freaked out himself when she recognised him in costume. It was hard to be angry at her, too, especially when she spoke in such a calm and... compassionate manner. Definitely harder to explode on than on Bruce or Tim and their cold *detective* approach towards things.

But he still didn’t *like* this feeling of being... seen-through? Didn’t like how easily she exposed things about him, even things he didn’t even realize himself. Should he be suspicious about her? Should he even be around her? She was plenty nice, but...

Julie continued before he could make a decision.

“And you never talked about it with anyone, because *you don’t want to bother them*. Because *this is your job*. Or because you never even realised what a toll it takes to live like this.”

Oh that. That was complete *bullcrap*. It was utter rubbish that he never asked for help. He had so many close people and he knew he could count on them if he needed any kind of assistance. It was a big part of his life, to have a broad and sturdy support network. And here she was, suggesting it was not—

He stopped mid-thought. She wasn’t suggesting he didn’t have anyone to back him up. She was suggesting that his broad support network was left unused, at least when it came to helping *him* rather than helping with *his things*. And, honestly. Ouch. Okay, that stung. This one he couldn’t deny at all and he didn’t like it. He didn’t remember what was the last time he spoke to someone about *himself* rather than about stuff that was happening around him. Rather than about someone’s issues.

Before he could comment, or even process this unpleasant realization, Julie added one last sentence, spoken fast and with one breath. Like she kinda feared she won’t have time to say it. Possibly because Dick still had his defiant, slightly unhappy expression on, like always when confronted with things he didn’t like. Possibly because she spent too much time with Jason, who would’ve exploded three minutes ago, if Dick knew anything about him.

“And I know it’s none of my business and you don’t even know me but I think that’s exactly why you need someone to talk to, to bounce your thoughts and emotions off and get it out and process it and even if you don’t want to change anything, at least let some steam off before the pot finally boils over, because when it does, you’re going to either *snap* or just *break* into a million depressed pieces and that’s the last thing I want to see because you deserve *so much more* and if you would allow me, I could be the person to help you to not reach that point, to not drown in bitter numbness .”

She fell silent. He kept silent. And blinked slowly. He didn’t expect... all of the things that just happened. All of those words and sudden comprehension. That sense of... being *seen*. Of being *known*.

His face softened momentarily. Someone who was essentially a stranger not only took the time to put the clues together and try to understand him on a level he didn’t know even *existed*, but also... cared enough to want to help him explore that level. That was... a lot. It felt like that one time Bruce had told him he loved him. Something that hit home, and stuck. Something that *made a difference* .

Julie must’ve seen that slight change because she hesitantly extended her arm towards him again. Before they knew, Nightwing had not only leaned into the touch, but laid down on the couch, resting his cheek against her side. She seemed surprised, but not taken aback. She didn’t jump or pull away. Instead, after a moment, she gently placed her hand on his head, stroking his hair slowly in a calming manner.

They stayed like that for a good while. Dick managed not to cry by closing his eyes. That would be bad for his reputation. And a terrible experience when you’re wearing a domino mask.

“Is this,” Nightwing began with a whisper, eyes still shut, “what you told Jay, too?”

“Not exactly. And not yet. He is... a work in progress. But we’re getting there.”

He snorted quietly. *A work in progress* was a rather mild descriptor for Jason’s temperament.

“Is this why he likes you? This feeling of...” he desperately looked for a word. It wasn’t happiness, no. It’s not that his life was magically better and he now understood himself and knew what to do. But... there was something... “Comfort?”

“I would hope so.”

He smiled. Then, slowly he looked up at her. “I don’t want to talk now.”

Dick was not ready. He suspected he might not be anytime soon. Maybe never. But the perspective of having the option to talk was good enough.

Julie nodded gently. “You don’t have to.”

“But maybe I’ll come around, one day,” Dick added.

“That’s the only thing I asked for.”

Nightwing wanted to say he needed to return to patrol, but at the same time, this weird mix of feeling both *lightness* and *heaviness* in his heart was too alluring to let go of. For once, he wanted to be selfish. Truly selfish.

No, not selfish. Self-caring. Finally not only not *alone*, but also not *lonely*.

So he stayed, until his comms inevitably murmured a “*Nightwing?*” in Batman’s harsh voice into his ear.

He waited for a moment before turning his mic on. He didn’t want to respond. “Yeah, B?” Julie looked down at him, a little worried, but he hushed her with a small wave of his hand.

“I haven’t heard anything from you tonight.”

“It is slow. Nothing to report.” Technically, it wasn’t even a lie.

“Where are you?”

He knew Batman could track him if he wanted, so there was no use lying. “At one of the safehouses. Stopped by for a snack. Fruity Oat Bits are hard to come by in Blüd,” Nightwing smiled, so the little play would show his voice.

A grunt could be heard on the other side. *“Get back home safely.”*

“On it, Bats. See ya.” And then a beep and static. Dick sighed, slowly getting up. “I’ll be going.”

Julie nodded in understanding. “You know where to find me if you need me,” she said, and then she smirked suddenly, and something about her tone changed, “you stalker.”

He laughed, suddenly and violently, caught off-guard by a joke after such a long time of... he couldn't really put a word to it, again. Stillness? Solemnity? Melancholy? *Intimacy* came to mind but it had a taste to it that didn't sound right. But maybe he was prejudiced. Maybe that was what he needed, he and his all unsatisfied hugs. Just some friendly, platonic intimacy. Without judgement, without pulling a face and acting annoyed, without pushing him away, like it felt with all the Bats. Without himself closing off to protect the other, like he always was with Wally, Donna or Gar. Without romantic feelings making it a high stakes hormones-driven game of making good impressions, like it was with Babs or Starfire. Just... sharing a moment with someone, nothing more, nothing less.

... sharing his burdens one day, maybe.

He saluted her with two fingers and slipped out the window to grapple away, the usual smile returning to his face, now feeling way more honest than before.

Chapter End Notes

We will be returning to regularly scheduled Jaybird soon.

Chapter 7: Jay

Chapter Summary

Jason experiences a [heel realization](#) and hates it.

Chapter Notes

Those who had read the previous chapter, Nightwing/Boy Wonder, right as I published it might want to re-read, as I changed quite a bit. The general content hasn't changed so as long as you read it you're good, but I improved on the delivery and been told it reads way better now.

TW: this is Jason's angry internal narrative. There's a lot of swearing. And a one-sentence description of gore.

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

Red Hood stared at the pathetic man sitting in front of him on a crumbling chair, tied roughly to it. One of the run down warehouses around the precinct once again got to serve a new purpose, and that night that purpose was being an interrogation room for him and his ~~victim~~ informant.

The man was already injured, incapacitated by Hood's first bullet to his leg. It was either the pain from that, and a couple of punches that followed, or the questioning that came after that made the man soil his pants. He grimaced under the helmed, thanking his past self for installing rebreathers. It must've smelled godawful because even with all the filters, it was so bad that the sour stink managed to stand out of the general nasty air of Gotham's most *prestigious* slum.

Jason already had enough names and other details to track down the people behind the attack on him and Juls, or at least get to the next link in the chain leading to the instigator. The point was, he could safely dispose of this guy and carry on. He could. He *could*. And after they tried to kill Juls? He absolutely *should*. Without hesitation or remorse.

He pressed the barrel of the gun to the man's forehead and growled, the helmet's voice mod making it even more primal and threatening. That earned him a whimper of fear from his captive.

Nobody messes with *his* people. Red Hood was the fucking *king* of this god-forsaken dump, save maybe in the eyes of Black Mask and some crime families who dared to question him. So those who picked up work against him? Ab-so-lu-tely stupid. He ought to make an example out of them. String their guts across the streets like fairy lights, starting with this guy. He had no *qualms* disposing of people in the past, and for lesser reasons than being involved in the attempted murder of his friends. You don't touch Hood's goddamn *ohana*, bitches, and live to tell the tale.

So why, why on Earth was he still only *aiming* ? Why wouldn't his finger pull the trigger?

Jason blinked and snapped out of his thoughts, focused his eyes, looked at the man again. He was shaking, sweating, pale in front of him. A complete nobody, now more than ever. Reduced to a trembling, begging for his life mess in front of him. What was his worth? Why was Jason even thinking about it?

Why was he *hesitating* ? Hesitating was *not* something he did. It was very unbecoming of Red Hood to second-guess his decisions. What was wrong with him?! What changed?!

And then he understood. Like a thunder running through his spine, the realization hit him hard and unexpected, straightening his body and mind in a single jolt.

Goddamn Juls.

Jason pulled the gun away, getting a slight sigh of relief from his prisoner. He took a step back. Then he started pacing around the room, a little nervously, trying to wrap his mind around his... revelation.

He never had issues offing people before, yes. Even now, when he kinda-sorta abstained from it to stay on Bats' good side (getting hunted by the entire Bat fam is just bad for business), he knew he would shoot to kill without as much as batting an eye if the situation called for it. His first instinct was always self-defence, whenever he had a gun or a tire iron in his hands. Tween Jay did *not* hesitate to hit as hard as he could or throw people off buildings if he deemed it necessary, and neither did the 20-something Jay.

Jason punched a wall, having had gotten worked up with anger. His prisoner made a frightened (and maybe a little confused) gasp.

The older, current Jason was considerably more trigger-happy and had definitely more blood on his hands. For Robin 2.0 though? It was few and far between to get someone to the other side, though not because of Batman's silly '*no-kill rule*'. It was because he had a *reason* to do it, every time. He did it *for* something, to achieve something, to protect or dish out justice or get vengeance, not because some people simply happened to be in the way or outlived their usefulness.

When did he become an egoistic sleazy brute like the rest of them, huh?

Baby Jay was an annoying little shit with a questionable moral compass and too much energy than he knew what to do with, sure, but he at least had *some* kind of moral compass nonetheless. And now? Now Jason was aiming at a guy who committed the grave crime of

being vaguely associated with people who pissed Jason off. And a few months back he almost shot Juls for daring to talk to him at the wrong moment. What the hell was wrong with him?

Jason groaned, then slowly made his way back to the guy bound to the chair.

“If I ever see you fucking around with the mafia again, I swear to god, you’re going to *wish* I had pulled the trigger tonight,” he snapped angrily at the goon, reluctantly untying him. Then Jason waved him off with his gun-wielding hand, and pointed towards the nearby door. The man looked at Hood hesitantly for a moment, then bolted — well, as much as you can *bolt* with and injured leg.

And that was all that Jason wanted. He didn’t need witnesses to his newfound major existential crisis.

Goddamn Juls. Juls and her words, and her lessons on fucking *emotions*, getting into his mind and making him *think*, making him *feel*.

He hated it. Oh, how he hated it. He hated admitting there was something wrong in how he was, in how he thought, how he acted. But there was no way around it — either years of getting fucked up and fucked over by pretty much everything, or the Pit, or maybe both (most probably both) made a cold-blooded murderous psychopath out of him. Violent and dangerous, just like Bats thought him to be at the beginning. And contrary to what he himself wanted to believe, not only to those he deemed *bad*. Also to bystanders. Also to those he cared about.

And fucking Juls made him realize it. Made him remember that this isn’t normal, this isn’t just how he is, that he hadn’t always been like this. It took a goody-two-shoes shrink that talked to him like he wasn’t, in his heart, a crime lord, like he wasn’t Red Hood, the guy that everybody with an ounce of self-preservation instinct feared like the plague... for him to remember he used to be a kid. A good kid, even. Instead of treating him like a threat — more or less contained, depending on the situation — like the Bats did (Jason absent-mindedly traced the Batarang scar on the side of his neck with his fingertips), she treated him like he was still little Robin. Like he was the teen always eager to take action, with a filthy mouth and a heart too big for his own damn good. Like he was just... Jay.

He sat down on the now unoccupied chairr, a little overwhelmed by all these thoughts.

Jason wanted to think she was very *wrong* about him, because if his first reaction was to try to shoot her, he must’ve been fucked up beyond salvation. He wanted to think he now was a violent psycho, for better or worse. He definitely got a mafia target on her back, which in itself was a reason to cut ties and save her the trouble and call himself a terrible person. He wanted to believe that, because that would’ve been *easier*. It’s always easier to keep the status quo. To not think, to not feel, to not *question*.

But he couldn’t believe that. He simply couldn’t. Because, somewhere deep inside, he hoped that she was *right*. That he still was little kid Robin, somehow. That he still fucking was Little Wing, maybe, as evidenced by his sudden inability to just shoot a random guy and carry on without missing a beat.

Maybe goddamn Juls was fucking right.

She said they became friends quite easily, back then. He could imagine that, if she was anything like her current self, so similar to the kid Jay he vaguely remembered. Just like him, she was eager to take action, with a heart too big for her own fucking good. Unlike him and his dirty, swearing little mouth, she had smiles for everybody, like Dick.

For a split second he mused how she's much like if he and Dick had a lovechild, and he immediately gagged at the thought, disgusted with the direction his mind went. He shook his head. But he couldn't deny that he liked Dick and treated him like a brother, back then at least, and if she was like Dickiebird but also a little more like Jay...

God, he had to like her *so much* as a kid. Jason only now realised that. And had problems comprehending the sheer intensity that their relationship must've had if he stayed with her for four damn years. If he told her his real name, and about Nightwing and Bats and his adventures as Robin and his family and everything else that mattered to him.

And then he tried to kill her. Now *that* said something about how ugly was the change in his character. The Pit-induced metamorphosis from annoying but likeable Robin to deadly and cold Red Hood. A classic face-heel turn, if you will, taken up to eleven. Like, sure, he also tried to kill Bruce and Tim and, well, basically everybody before, but one, he remembered them and thought they betrayed him (he still did think that, in some regard), and two, back then he was *fucking sky high on Lazarus Pit fumes*. When he tried to shoot her he considered her a stranger and himself to be fully mentally stable. And yet...

~~God maybe Bruce was right about killing being a slippery slope and Jason hated this possibility.~~

Maybe it was time for his redemption arc, he thought. If he deserved one. If he could pull one off. He wouldn't get any better chances, that was for sure. If he would get any more chances at all.

Jason looked at the gun still in his hand. Not killing willy-nilly, not because Batman said so, but because he thought it was the right thing to do would be a good starting point. What else, though? How does one go about becoming... less violent? Less of a menace? While also, hopefully, still striking fear into the hearts of people who don't deserve to walk this earth, let alone any mercy?

He wasn't sure how at all. Maybe he should give guns up? They definitely were enabling him to pursue his more... manic tendencies. Yet undoubtedly, his best suit was marksmanship. Sure, he wasn't bad in close quarters either, and if he trained a bit he could definitely match even Bruce, especially with his rather bulky posture... but he just didn't want to give up his best and favorite skill. There was something about guns that felt like it... made him stand out against other Gotham vigilantes (god could he even still call himself a *vigilante* at this point? Was he much different from a villain?). Draw a line between him and his past. He wanted to stop being a murderous maniac, for sure. But he knew he can't just pretend like nothing happened, and a clear border between little Jay and him was needed. A clear border between him and the Bats, too.

One way or another, he wanted to keep guns in his arsenal. Maybe he should just swap *all* his bullets for rubber ones, instead of just about half to appease B? Having live ammo on him made it way easier to relapse back to the ‘*maybe let’s just kill them and be done with it*’ way of thinking.

He groaned, standing up as the night wasn’t getting any younger.

That was some idea. But he’d think about it more later. For now, he had a whole branch of mafia to explain to why the little Kids’ Psych Center in Park Row was staying, and staying intact, even if it was making their business harder.

Especially if it was making their business harder. Because that implied they were using kids in it, and as far as Red Hood remembered, he gave clear rules — **nobody touches the kids**. Nobody recruits kids, nobody deals to kids, nobody fucking even bothers kids in his territory. It was apparently time to refresh those rules to *some* people.

Jason holstered his gun to grapple into the night towards his next target, and groaned once again. Goddamn Juls. How the fuck did she get to him this easily?

He snorted at that thought almost immediately after it appeared in his mind.

Easily. It’s been what, almost a year since they met. Well, this time at least. If one didn’t count the time they knew each other before he went and got resurrected, she definitely didn’t know him long. But if you count that, you realize she knew him the longest, even if you include people like Dick... And when you add to it all the fact she was a trained psychologist, graduated with honors if he remembered right... It wasn’t much of a surprise that she could read him like an open book.

And maybe it was a good thing.

Easily, ha! She spent a year trying to befriend a violent psycho, even after he tried to kill her at the start, just because she saw a hurt little kid in him. Kid needing help just like the kids in the Crime Alley she risked her life for.

Easily, fuck. Jason shook his head at his own stupidity. Damn Juls deserved a Nobel Peace Prize, not someone saying she did all the incredible things she did ‘*easily*’.

He’ll have to get her something nice after this mess is cleaned up. Maybe he’ll buy her a new game for her console. Maybe he’ll get her tickets for that one movie she wanted to see. Maybe he’ll simply take her out for Thai food again. She did say she loved that one uptown restaurant, and she smiled more than usual that day.

Jason smirked, suddenly in that very second knowing what would make Juls the happiest girl in the city. If instead of Thai food he’d just tell her *thank you*.

Or maybe he’ll simply tell her that over the most expensive Tom yum goong he’ll find.

Thank you for being patient with this a little slower update time :)
@ the person who user-subbed me: I love you.

If after this chapter you're worried this is going to spiral into romance, fret not, this is going to stay platonic. Just a lil' intense.

If after this chapter you're hoping this is going to spiral into friends to lovers, subscribe.

If the world allows it there's going to be a fic with an alternate ending that will be going the romance route.

Chapter 8: Robin

Chapter Summary

No thirteen-year-old is immune to bribing with video games.

Grayson had been acting a little strange the past few days, so Damian decided to — in true Batman style — check what’s going on and stalk Nightwing’s latest moves a bit. His plan of action was to check Grayson’s logs, where and what did he do, which files he opened from the Batcomputer, and so on, and then follow up on leads he would deride from those without alerting anyone. If Nightwing was in trouble that he hadn’t said anything about, heading straight for Father would only make the situation worse. He also didn’t want to be seen as needing support from elders like a child. If Nightwing *wasn’t* in trouble, but decided to keep some *suspicious* secrets anyway, Damian would *gladly* gain leverage on him by acquiring this guarded information.

That’s how he spent some hours in the Batcave, going through the historical files, pretending his best to be reading up on clues to their current case. It was a good enough lie, especially since it was a half-truth. It was a case, it was recent. He was also planning on checking up on the clues to their *actual* case eventually that evening. So technically, he wasn’t going to lie.

Pennyworth wouldn’t be mislead by these attempts at deceit, of course. But the butler would also just politely offer evening tea and smirk at Damian and not make a single comment. Loyal to a fault, and clever like a fox, he was a dangerous man. Damian was *so* glad Alfred was an ally, because he’d make a *very scary* enemy.

Not long after the butler left, though, Drake appeared, strutting in like he owned the place.

“What are *you* doing here?” Damian scoffed, barely looking up from the screen. He luckily had been changing the displayed file to something relevant to the actual case, which he had open in case of situations like this, every time he heard someone enter the room.

“What are **you** doing here, is the question,” Drake barked back without missing a beat, then took a sip out of the mug he was holding in his hands.

“I *live* here, you imbecile.”

“Finally moved into the Cave so that your surroundings match your nasty attitude a little bit more?” the other man leaned against the empty workspace of the Batcomputer and looked up at the screen with rising curiosity. “Ooh, digging through Bruce’s secret files when he’s busy? Naughty,” he snarked despite clearly seeing what the open file was.

Damian growled, half angered naturally, half to keep up the pretense. “Don’t measure me with your own yard-stick, Drake. I would never go against Father like that.”

Drake snorted and smirked ironically. And even though Drake hadn’t said anything, he didn’t have to. Damian knew he didn’t believe a word he heard. It was only fair, as Damian already *did* go against his Father like that before. Red Robin maybe didn’t know exactly what Damian was looking up, but *Cunning* could as well be Drake’s middle name. Saying anything more would just give him more clues on to what Damian was doing.

And this? Something that Grayson had hidden from them? This was something he definitely wanted to be the only one to figure out, or at least be the *first* to do so.

Knowing he can’t fool Drake, he opted for covering up his tracks. In a few swift motions Damian logged off and shut the session down, then dynamically pushed himself away from the cockpit.

“I can’t work like this, your idiocy will rub off on me,” he muttered angrily and stood up. He gave Drake one last menacing glance and stomped off. But not before stealthily swiping some gear on his way out. If he can’t get info from the digital data, he will just have to get it first-hand. And the info he needed was definitely in that safehouse Nightwing visited recently so much for no apparent reason.

He quietly dropped onto the windowsill, peeking through the window tentatively. Damian wasn’t sure what to expect, in anything at all. Would Nightwing be stupid careless enough to leave any obvious traces of whatever his dubious activity was? It would depend heavily on how rushed he felt, and how special his secret was. Damian considered what the nature of it could be.

The safehouse certainly looked *lived in* , so it left Damian no doubts Nightwing had been spending time there. The use of a physical space suggested it was something physical to hide; maybe he had gotten himself something that Father wouldn’t allow in the Manor and Richard needed it in Gotham, not Blüdhaven? Maybe he wanted to keep a project secret? Was anyone’s birthday coming up? Hiding something from Alfred would definitely need it to be out of the Manor... It was all possible. Damian needed more information.

Given how proficient at hacking and how annoyingly nosy both Oracle and Drake were, Nightwing could’ve as well decided to keep some sort of information in analog form instead and then attempt to hide it in this safehouse. Maybe he was following up on a case that he didn’t want anyone else meddling with? That would be much like him. If that was the case, Damian would certainly make sure to assist him anyway. If he had figured it out, Father would soon follow and Richard would need all the help to wrap things up before that happened.

Damian disarmed the alarm, quietly opened the window and slipped inside. He was careful not to disrupt anything too much on the off chance he didn’t want Richard to know he was there.

That sentiment soon crumbled to pieces in the next five seconds.

He drew his blade quicker than his brain registered what he's seeing, instincts kicking in before he could process the absolutely *bizarre* sight before him.

A stranger. Clearly feeling quite *at home*. In their safehouse.

If she was a superhero, he'd recognise her, so he ruled that out. The only heroes he *could've* not recognised were possibly new or obscure ones. So it was either that, or simply a civilian. The alarm was active when he arrived, and it was hard to believe just about anybody could hack it, so she had to be *let in* by someone who knew the codes. Richard was here not long ago, too, so probably it was him who brought her, or he at least knew about her. Why would he bring a stranger in to one of their *secret* places? Why would he *hide* it from them all?

... was Richard having an affair? Or *worse*, was he getting a *sidekick*?

He made a couple quick steps towards her and pointed his blade at her throat. She froze, possibly only then noticing him. She then slowly looked up at him from the cellphone she was holding and raised her arms above her head.

"Uh, hi?" she said, her voice trembling just a *little* bit, which made Damian think she knew she was trespassing.

She was taller than him, though not by much for an adult, but definitely heavier set. Was there muscle under the chub? He couldn't tell, even through the lounge wear she had on. But the way she stood, feet wide and hips low, steady, made him think she wasn't just a random civilian. On the other hand, it *was* Gotham and anyone with half a brain had some street smarts.

"Identify yourself," he barked out.

"I'm Julianna Powell. Nice to meet you, Robin?" she smiled weakly. Damian squinted and scoffed, not amused by her pathetic attempt to derail the situation.

"What are you doing here?"

"I'm— Can we talk *without* a weapon between us?" she pleaded. "I'm pretty sure you realise I'm clearly no match for you anyway. It would be nice not to have you pointing a sword at me. Not a big fan of fighting, really."

"What are you doing here?" he repeated his question, making one step forward threateningly. He was not going to get side-tracked like that.

She sighed in defeat, though her shoulders stiffened as the blade approached her. "I'm hiding out. There's someone after me, apparently, and, well. I can't go back home for now."

"-tt-" he clicked his tongue again, irritated even more because it *made sense*. But not enough of it. He still had too many questions. He knew she isn't telling him the entire truth "Why here?"

“Didn’t have anywhere else to go.” She sighed, looking him up and down, as if weighing her options. Then, possibly judging he will press further, she continued to explain. “Nightwing brought me here. He thought it’d be the safest option.”

Damian scoffed. “And why should I believe you?”

She shrugged. “Nothing I say would be a good answer to that,” she replied, relaxing a little, as if she thought she convinced him. “But you already decided, right? Can you lower the sword now, Robin? Please?”

Damian looked at her, squinting, for a moment longer, then slowly sheathed his katana. It was true she’d be no match for him, even if he hid his weapon. And if she indeed was just a civilian, it would be... not desirable to threaten her, anyway. Father and Richard both would be *disappointed* in him displaying such a behaviour.

She — Powell, yes? — lowered her arms and sat on the armrest on the sofa. He eyed her, still a little suspicious, but before he could react, she started talking in a soft, relaxed tone. Kind of similar to Richard’s when he’s worried, or maybe Alfred’s. Unconsciously, Damian relaxed his jaw and shoulders, too.

“What brings you here?” she asked, placing her cellphone on the coffee table. “If you need the place for something, I promise you won’t even notice I’m around. I also didn’t touch any of the... *stuff*. You know, the computer, any tech things, so on. I’m really just playing games on the TV all day lately, being locked up and all. Just circling between kitchen, bathroom, bed and sofa the past days.”

Only then he looked around properly, to analyze the surroundings. The room wasn’t as *immaculate* as it would be without anyone living there, but tidy enough to support her claims of having very little impact on the place. There was an old cup of tea and a half-eaten bowl of cereal on the coffee table. Other than that, nothing really was changed, and all the systems were still locked by the looks of it. Just the TV was on, and some kind of game console hooked up to it, with a game paused menu on the display. From under the menu, a weird, simple, square-looking entity looked at him, straight through the TV.

He tilted his head. “Is that a *cow*?” Damian asked, his voice a mix of *disgusted* and *confused* tones, him finally recognising what the squares were supposed to represent.

She followed his line of sight to the television and smiled. “Yep! It’s my Minecraft farm. Been passing the time by making enclosures for cows and pigs and horses, and collecting as many ocelots as I can.”

He immediately shifted his focus back to her, suspicious.

“And why are you suddenly so friendly, huh?”

Powell blinked, a little confused. “Because you’re a superhero and I have nothing to fear? I mean, sure, you’re a little more abrasive than one would usually expect from a hero, but you’re Robin. You’re a good kid. Why *wouldn’t* I be friendly?”

She... had a point. He had been excessively hostile upon finding a trespasser on their property, and paranoidly distrustful like a true Bat. But if she really had no ill intentions, then an encounter with one of the renowned Gotham vigilantes shouldn't be filled with tension.

Both ways.

He slowly raised his hand and pointed to the screen.

"Why is the cow all square?"

Powell smiled. "That's just how Minecraft is!" she reached out towards one of the brightly colored controllers and unpaused the game. The room immediately filled with peaceful, quiet mooing and oinking as the crude creatures on screen began to wobble about.

Damian slowly walked a little bit closer and gave the game a closer look. She moved the joystick on the controller she held, showing him more of the virtual world.

"I'm surprised someone your age doesn't know Minecraft. I'm guessing you don't spend much time on video games?"

"-tt- I've got more important things to do."

Powell made a non-committal sound of agreement, but then extended her arm towards him and offered the controller. "Wanna check it out?"

He hesitated for a moment. He came here for entirely different reasons. But there wasn't much of a mystery to unveil here, and so most of his plans became null and void. He... he had some time to burn.

Damian slowly approached her and took the controller in his hand.

"You use the joystick to move around—" she pointed to one of the various input knobs on the controller, "and this button to interact with stuff—"

He pushed the button hesitantly, pointing the camera at the cow on the screen, and it mooed happily as hearts flew around it. And that was how Damian sold his soul to Minecraft.

Chapter 9: Son of Batman

Chapter Notes

I didn't have this entirely finished and edited, so there's already some weird transitions and not-fic at the end here.

Three hours later Robin knew how to befriend and breed most of the animals in the game, and had re-structured Powell's poorly-built farm to optimize it towards the needs of the animals kept on the premises. Just half an hour in, the woman gave him the reins completely and simply sat back and just explained the various mechanics from time to time. Damian picked them up very fast — it was a children's game, after all, and he was *Batman's son* — so the silence between them gradually morphed into awkward exchange of information, and then a rather stiff (like most of Damian's talks), but natural conversation.

"You're quite fond of animals, aren't you."

"Yes. They're good and innocent."

"Even the predators?"

"They don't attack without provocation. Only out of necessity."

"Unlike humans?"

Damian eyed her for a moment, then returned to building the new, better pasture fence.

"Unlike humans. Most are cruel for no reason."

"I don't quite agree," she said nonchalantly, but it sounded like she tried to get a reaction out of him. When Damian remained silent, she continued. "I think everything humans do was *provoked* somehow, has a reason, a *necessity* behind it. Sometimes we don't understand what kind of reasoning there is, even the person who's acting might not understand... but we aren't random. And we aren't bad, either, at the core."

He scoffed. "You're quite idealistic for a Gothamite."

"Oh definitely," she laughed. "You're not the first person to say that. I still stand by my point, though."

"You haven't seen what I saw."

"I imagine you saw many things someone your age shouldn't see while out there, fighting crime."

“I’m not a *child*. I can handle it,” he hissed.

“I know you can. But the question is, should you?”

Damian paused for a moment, only barely keeping himself from blinking in confusion. Powell continued, taking his lack of reaction as an encouragement, it seemed.

“People your age should enjoy life and grow up to be the best versions of themselves. Should be happy and loved,” the woman said, and sighed. “They say tough times build character but...” she trailed off for a moment, looking out the window past him wistfully. There seemed to be something on her mind, as her expression changed *ever-so-slightly*, for just a split moment before she spoke again. “Broken bones heal, but they’re never the same. They leave scars and pain and bad memories. Same goes for minds; if we ever take care of them enough for them to heal — which we often don’t — we’re changed forever.”

“That’s just how the world is. It’s not fair. It’s not all rainbows and butterflies,” he snarked, a little annoyed at how out of touch she sounded. Even Richard, the most optimistic of them all, wasn’t this *deluded*.

“Yeah, and yet, here you are, spending your nights risking your life in costume to make it a little better.”

Damian didn’t reply for a while. Then, he decided to cut the chase. “What’s your point?”

“My point is, you’re a good kid. I hope life is as good to you as you are to others. And if it’s not, I’m willing to make it a little bit better, if only by playing Minecraft with you.”

“I don’t need you,” Damian hissed again. “I have a family that cares for me.”

“Yeah, I know. I hope you have, at least. I just wish you had someone to talk to about why you’re angry and scared.”

He was getting annoyed. Firstly, she was talking like she knew him, and secondly, she was distracting him from the piggies.

“I’m angry because everybody around me is an *incompetent fool*,” he snapped. “And I’m not scared of *anything*!”

Powell smiled in the sad way that Alfred and Richard sometimes did. He didn’t comment on it.

“I doubt you consider Batman an incompetent fool?”

“He is an *exception*. ”

“Does he work on getting you away from people who make you angry, then?”

Damian didn’t want to answer, but he knew he doesn’t *have to* for her to know the real answer. Still, he decided to say something, anything, if only to keep his reputation.

"You wouldn't understand," he said after a moment of consideration. "Vigilantes are different."

"You're still a human person. You deserve respect and love and support. You deserve not to be angry all the time."

"Believe me, I've tried!" he snapped, finally pausing the game and looking at her, an hostile growl stuck in his throat. "But Red Robin and Red Hood don't die as easily as they should."

As soon as he said it, he realised he shouldn't have. It would impact the reputation of Batman and his allies for the public to know that there's inside fighting. Sure, they've had their share of... public *misunderstandings* but nothing civilians would be concerned about or is too much of a hassle to cover up. And he just babbled about his death wishes for the two previous Robins.

Powell didn't seem to be too shaken about it, though. As if, curiously enough, she was expecting it.

"Batman defended them, or they managed to get away on their own?" she asked simply.

"...both," he admitted, caught off-guard by the chill way she reacted to his words.

"Wouldn't that mean they're at least *a bit* capable?"

He hissed in annoyance. "When I'll be their age, I'll be way better."

She made another of her agreeing noises, and shrugged a bit. "That's how aging in general and growing up with mentors sorta works. Older people know more not by virtue of being somehow fundamentally better, but because they simply saw more," she said, but before he could argue with her, she pointed at the controller in his hands, and continued. "Like judging by how you're doing, you're going to be a Minecraft whiz in no time. I've been playing it for months, if not years now. Three hours ago I was better at it and I'll still be for some time, if only because you hadn't played survival mode yet. And yet, am I an incapable fool?"

Robin scoffed. What a stupid question. "You yourself admitted you'd lose in a fight against me."

"I'm not talking about fighting, I'm talking about Minecraft. There's more to life than fighting, right? Petting cows, for example," she grinned, and Damian couldn't help but agree. His animals meant the world to him, and he spent copious amounts of time caring for them and learning about them.

"I guess yes, you're better at this game than I am. What does that have to do with anything?"

"Why aren't you angry about me not being a good fighter, or about being better than you at something?"

"Because I don't care about you," he replied, absolutely serious.

She snorted a quiet laugh, and nodded. "Fair. Does that mean you care about Red Robin and Red Hood?"

"No! They're annoying because they get in the way. They think they're better, but they're not."

"Better at what?"

He frowned.

"At being a vigilante."

Powell nodded again, then supplied a different version: "At being Batman's son?"

Damian huffed. He definitely didn't want to answer *that* one.

"At being something you care about," she rephrased, seeing his frown deepening. "The game is something you just picked up, and you could put it down and forget about it in no time. But you're Batman's son, and your place is at his side, isn't it? And there's these guys who think they're better at it, who are stealing your rightful spot. And they *aren't losing*, like they should."

His shoulders stiffened and he slowly reached towards a Batarang. "Who the hell are you?"

Powell grinned, but Damian noticed that she must've seen the change in his attitude because she immediately became more nervous. "A good conversationalist," she answered. "Nightwing can vouch talking to me is kinda fun."

He didn't grace her with a response and she didn't press any further. Possibly she understood that any more philosophical nonsense would just annoy him. Possibly having had said everything she wanted him to know that day.

Damian went back to the game for another while, until it was time to get back and prepare for patrol, pretending nothing happened that day. He wouldn't want people to ask why he was here. He didn't want Richard to think he doesn't trust him; or Drake to figure out this... *weakness* he showed here, playing games like a child; or Father to get into an argument with Richard over Nightwing's decision to hide a civilian in their safe house. Instead, he decided to keep this encounter with the woman and the square cows entirely to himself.

"Hey," Powell spoke when he placed the controller on the coffee table and stood up, heading towards the window. He paused, and looked at her over his shoulder without a word, eyebrows high in a questioning expression. The woman reached for her nearby backpack and produced a small white card out of it, then proceeded to scribble something on it.

She offered it to him in an extended hand. "If you ever wanna hang out again, hit me up," she said, smiling. Damian, surprisingly, found himself grabbing the card — with what looked like her phone number and possibly a pseudonym of some kind? — and after brief inspection, putting it into one of his pockets with a nod.

“Alfred?” the boy said, approaching one of his guardians a good few days later. The butler was carefully assembling packed lunch for Damian. The bag was already full of cut-up vegetables for snacking, and a portion of tofu curry would soon make its way in there too.

“Yes, Master Damian?”

“I require new art supplies and therefore want to pay a visit to the shopping centre. Would it be possible for you to pick me up later, from the premises, instead of right after school?”

It was a long shot. Alfred was by far the most cunning out of them all, possibly even better than Father when it came to seeing through them. He was a force to be reckoned with, and would understand there’s more to Damian’s request than a simple shopping trip. Would he play along, though?

Alfred smiled warmly and zipped up the lunch bag, then handed it to Damian. “Won’t you need someone with you, Master Damian?”

He scoffed, and would cross his arms over his chest if he wasn’t holding the bag. “I don’t need a guardian to guide me through *the shops*.”

“You’re quite a self-sufficient lad, young sir, but you’re still legally a child, and a Wayne to that. It would be unwise to let you roam freely out in the public, where you wouldn’t be able to use your skills to defend yourself lest you wanted to reveal the truth about your... nightly activities.”

The butler’s smile was saying everything about whenever or not Alfred saw through Damian’s charade. The boy frowned, but before he could answer, the elderly man continued.

“Could I suggest we make the trip together after your school is finished, instead?” he asked with a fond smile. Damian pondered for a moment. It was a bargain he was willing to make; he knew he could trust Alfred not to judge or reveal his purchases to the others.

The boy nodded and stuffed the lunch into his school bag, content with the perspective of what would come later that day.

Art supplies weren’t just a *lie*. Damian Al Ghul-Wayne didn’t just outright lie. He simply... omitted some facts. He *always* wanted more paints and brushes. The fact that he’d also like to visit the electronics store nearby was... irrelevant.

Alfred allowed him to wander the unfamiliar aisles alone, maybe because he deemed them safe enough, or because he wanted to give Damian privacy with his little secret. Either way, Damian was glad, as the last thing he’d like Pennyworth to see was him staring with wide eyes at a box in his hands.

“Do you need a hand, kiddo?” came a voice from next to him, and Damian nearly jumped in surprise. It was embarrassing to be there *at all*, let alone be addressed like a *plebeian* or being *startled*.

He turned around and looked slightly up, at the man in a red polo shirt and with a fake smile plastered to his face. A shopkeeper, if one was to judge by the logo on the shirt.

“Do you have these in black?” Damian motioned around with the brightly colored box he held. The employee smiled and nodded.

“Looking for any games to go with it?”

Damian pondered for a moment whenever he should disclose any more information. Deciding it won’t hurt, he nodded slightly. “Minecraft.”

Another smile came in as a response and the employee gestured for him to wait while he grabbed the items. Half an hour later he paid for his purchases with cash and hid them deep within his backpack so that nobody could see what they were. He didn’t want anyone, including Alfred, to know. It felt too much like a weakness to enjoy... *age-appropriate entertainment*. The last thing he needed was ridicule from the other Waynes.

At home, he set up the console *without* hooking it up to any bigger screen; he needed to be able to hide all evidence at a moment’s notice. The only problem that remained was a user account — having something vaguely tied to his name (through the card payment, for example) and formally *public* was already bad. He didn’t want to think how compromising it could be if that account was ever connected to his vigilante alias, but knew it would have to happen. On the other hand, he was pretty sure nobody would bat an eye about a kid (*technically* he was one, but hated admitting it) having a superhero-themed online username, the same way nobody gave a second thought about Jon wearing a super-S T-shirt.

Damian bit his lip and typed in his first idea, wondering if it’d be free for the taking. It, of course, wasn’t. It was simple enough that people must’ve thought of it before. So he tried out several more, until he found one that was unique *and* appropriately dignified for him to use, and finally could properly launch the game. Getting used to the UI took him a total of maybe 15 seconds — he was a genius, and it was designed to be easy and intuitive. With that, he created a new world and immersed himself in play.

Hours later, Damian looked proudly at his sprawling farms and the vast paddocks full of happy animals. It was easy to get into it, and surprisingly relaxing, in an artistic kind of way, despite how simplistic and seemingly *pointless* the game was. He could understand why it pulled kids to it like a magnet, why it was a popular past time.

And, as he realised looking at the redstone guide on his phone, it could also be considered a way to boost creative and logical thinking; so if anybody asked, it wasn’t time *wasted*. Still, he couldn’t spend too much on it lest he wanted others to become suspicious. He exited to menu, then closed the game and went to exercise for a bit before patrol time came. Nobody would be the wiser that he spent the time in his room playing instead of painting, studying or something similarly usual for him.

That’s how the next week or so went for him — going on about his day, and night, too, and in the meantime spending a good chunk of his free time immersed in the game. Then, one evening, he hesitated before turning it off. For a moment, he stared at the Friends tab, pondering. The string of letters written on Powell’s card almost *definitely* was her online

handle, intended for him to find her by, should he want to contact her. Did he want to? Damian found it hard to decide. Playing on his own was fun, and just like Father, he preferred being alone. But on the other hand, playing with someone else would be... interesting. He could ask Jon, who almost certainly also had this game or at least would love to play, but that would mean everybody would know of Damian's little secret in no time — Jon was a terrible blabbermouth. That, he couldn't have. So the only other option was to...

A brief moment later, he typed in her username from memory, sent the friend request, and left, not wanting to dwell on what he just did. Hoping he wouldn't regret it later.

The next day, just after his post-school repast with Pennyworth, he closed the door to his room behind him as always, but found himself entering a completely new world instead of revisiting his own creation.

BloodRobin logged in. jPow: hey there! havent seen you online before

jPow: what would you like me to call you?

BloodRobin: Robin

jPow: okay! A fan, huh? me too!

Damian rolled his eyes.

jPow: well what brings you here? how do we know each other?

Damian pondered it for a moment. Did he want to identify himself?

BloodRobin: you got briefly acquainted with my blade

The pause before a reply was longer than just typing time. Damian couldn't tell if she was trying to figure out what he referenced, or trying to formulate an appropriate response.

jPow: ooooooh man yeah i know what you mean! hi!!

Definitely the first, then. It's been a couple of weeks since they met, but she couldn't be *that* daft and forgetful, could she? It *must've been* a rather memorable incident in her life, the whole staying at a safehouse thanks to Nightwing, meeting Robin et cetera.

jPow: im so happy you finally decided to join then !!

jPow: i redid the rest of the pastures like how you started back then!

jPow: wanna help me dig up some cobble? we've started a castle with the other kids

Damian sighed. Online, she sounded much like Jon, overenthusiastic and hyper. It was both annoying and kind of... reassuringly familiar.

He hadn't built a castle before. He decided he might as well try.

BloodRobin: what kind of castle?

jPow: ?

BloodDamian: a square stone keep? A star fort? Motte and bailey?

jPow: i didn't know there's different types of castles! can you tell me more?

Damian huffed, irritated. Of course. They probably just went along with whatever fantastical concept of a stone fortification a group of kids had in mind.

But he wouldn't be himself if he passed a chance to boast his knowledge and prove his superiority. And so, he started typing.

Powell, surprisingly, didn't try to disprove his expertise — so unlike many (if not even *most*) adults he'd met. Instead, she asked questions and stated her own hypotheses, making their chats more akin to an academic exchange than an adult listening to a teen. Damian liked that very much, as it not only stroked his ego, but also provided the kind of validation he didn't know he craved; craved from someone other than goons from the League of Assassins, anyway.

The topics for their conversations varied. That day they talked about castles, and later, other days, about architecture, physics, global geopolitics, social structure of Gotham, psychology, and many other things. Sometimes they'd play in silence. Sometimes there were other kids on the server; at first he avoided those times, but once Powell proved she can reign them in, Damian naturally enjoyed having a team to lead and order around even in the virtual reality. If the topic wasn't entirely out of their league, the children would also tune in with interest, and sometimes, much to Damian's shock, even with vaguely relevant insight.

Those were, as it turned out, possibly the most valuable results of the entire affair. Rarely was he in an environment that was both *controlled* and *hospitable* (and did not include violence), so having adequate adult supervision in peer contact came as something new. Sure, Father and Richard and Pennyworth also reminded him to use proper language, and to uphold the vigilante code they subscribed to, but... but none of them demanded that he *behaved*. They'd stop him if he ever posed a *real* danger to Drake these days, for example, but his jabs and verbal threats and non-lethal-non-mission-failing hits on the previous Robin went without much else than a wince on Richard's face.

But in the game?

For the first time ever, it was *him* who felt threatened. It was a new feeling.

jPow: Robin! Stop taking Mart's house apart please

BloodRobin: it's ugly

He took out another block out of the wall.

MarnieBarnie: your face is ugly!!!

BloodRobin: you've never even seen me

MarnieBarnie: i dont have to! ur ugly

jPow: boys.

Firezone: uh oh

No1BatgirlFan: i sense a disturbance in the force. guys you better chill out or the bans are dropping

Damian stopped working on disassembling the disgusting building, instead opting on waiting to see how the situation would develop.

jPow: what are the rules, Mart?

MarnieBarnie: he started it!!!

jPow: yes, he did. And it's his first strike. You do know better than that, though, right?

MarnieBarnie: yeah

jPow: you need a moment? I promise to protect your house in the meantime

MarnieBarnie: nah. I'm sorry I called you ugly, Robs.

He stared at the screen in confusion. What was going on? This made little sense to him.

jPow: Great! I'm proud of you, Mart!! <3 I'm sure next time you'll get it before you call someone names

jPow: now, Robin. What are the rules?

Oh that, he knew. He knew the rules. Proper language and being kind to each other, blah blah blah, basic peasant etiquette.

BloodRobin: I didn't break any

Firezone: dude you started destroying Marts build without a word and kept on when he told you to stop that's grieving

Damian grimaced and quickly searched the term up on the internet through his phone, because he was pretty sure the other boy wasn't using the word by the proper dictionary definition.

BloodRobin: I didn't ruin anything for him, I was making it better

MarnieBarnie: you took apart half of my wall!!! how is that making it better!!!

He rolled his eyes and sighed, then started typing. He should've figured that they'll need an explanation of the *obvious*.

BloodRobin: cobble walls look better than wood

jPow: but did you ask if he wanted it to be made of cobblestone?

BloodRobin: ... I did not.

jPow: and what is it called when in a game you change other people's things without asking. and they're angry about it?

His frown only deepened when the realisation hit him.

He was, by all means a griever, intentional or not. And that was... not a name he would like to be identified with. Especially not if it meant he would be banned from the server. So, he turned his character around and left.

jPow: not so fast buddy!!!

jPow: I see you understand the error of your ways. Now it's time to apologise and help repair what you broke.

Damian grumbles, but what other choice did he have?

With time, Damian noticed the approach he was forced to take during those gaming sessions not only became more natural and less annoying over time, but also seeped into his other activities. He was usually known as the most violent and possibly least friendly Robin. And yet, his success rate of comforting victims quite frankly... skyrocketed. Much to his dismay, he's been *personally proven* that approaching others, especially kids, with a feeling of superiority was a rather... poor tactic. And so, he attempted to... *curb* his usual *attitude*, if only for the sake of the mission. There was a time when Powell explained it to him by drawing a comparison between how one should treat children and how he already approached animals. It somehow helped him extend his compassion from one to another, make it more of an instinct. Even if it later felt very weird to realise he was equating humans and animals, in any way.

There was even a time or two when he caught himself reading her words with heed, intrigued at what she might have to say. It turned out she, despite certainly being far less educated, knew her fair share about things, sometimes also topics he himself hadn't had time to look into. And though both of them were fairly adept at typing, neither the handheld console nor the game interface itself *weren't made* for long discussions about philosophy; it was slow and clunky, and more than once Damian became irritated at how limited the exchange was because of it.

[Damian visits the safehouse again only to find it empty.]

Chapter 10: Tim

Chapter Notes

Fully summary/notfic.

Juls is eventually freed from the safehouse-arrest.

Tim notices Damian acting weird, and all the other things that are slightly off with the safehouse, Nightwing's and Red Hood's meetings etc. He follows the leads until he finds out about Julianna. He decides to learn more about her and goes "undercover", i.e. stumbles into her as a civilian. They talk and establish rapport, and Tim soon understands why his family likes her. He befriends her and over time, she becomes his almost-confidante, too.

The time he spends with Julianna teaches Tim that not being self-sufficient is okay. That it's okay to ask for help. That isolating yourself and compartmentalizing your emotions isn't very healthy. That there are so many people around him that would like to get closer to him, if he just let them.

And he... does, tentatively. Mostly because in the background, Wayne family's general emotional situation improves. Jason becomes a more frequent guest at the Manor, Damian apologises to Tim. Dick practices some self-love every once in a while.

Partially because he actually enjoys her company, partially to pull a prank on everybody, Tim invites Juls to a family dinner at the Nest. Throughout the evening, as all the other vigilantes arrive and talk, it slowly dawns on them that unbeknownst to others, they've befriended the same person lately AND that very person is also going to be a guest here. Dick and Damian freak out that she will know their secret identities, and that this is very risky in general. Tim dismisses these doubts.

When Julianna arrives, she indeed starts slowly connecting the dots - but in an "Oh, so this is the brother you were talking about?" and "I understand your troubles so much better now" way. Tim is amused because he already knew that that was how it was going to go. Even if Juls figured out who they were, she would not care all that much. Jason is surprised at first, but it kind of makes sense because Juls is just a civilian after all. He's just kind of disappointed about her not figuring it out, though.

Eventually, Julianna *does* connect the dots when she realises how the chronology of their lives matches up and that they've been all adopted by Bruce Wayne, or at least it seems so, because she goes...

"Oh. Does... Does that mean that it's true? Bruce Wayne really is... he's really dating Batman?"

And everyone else at the table just loses their shit, laughing.

Chapter 11: Epilogue

Chapter Notes

Fully notfic/summary.

Julianna becomes a permanent fixture in the lives of the batboys. Just like she always was for Jason, she's kind of an anchor, a beacon of normalcy contrasting with their dangerous lives and vigilantism. She also is an excellent shoulder to lean on when death and violence and stress become just... too much.

Eventually, she also starts helping them - talks to ghosts of victims to figure out what happened and who is responsible, for example. When they have to talk about her in-costume, they refer to Juls as "Goose". Partially because she's a self-appointed "silly goose", someone who views the world in simple, grounded ways and doesn't try to come off as too serious (like *they* do). Partially because much like geese, she relies *exclusively* on intimidation when threatened, and if anyone figures out just how harmless she is, she's in great trouble.

At the complete end, Julianna finally gathers courage to ask Jason if he'd be willing to pass something on to Bruce Wayne for her. He hesitates, but agrees. She hands him a handful of old, but well-preserved pearls. It's implied that they're from Martha Wayne's necklace, and that she helped Bruce's parents pass on by promising she'll return these to their son.

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